



History For Languages

Senior Four



Student's Book

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FOREWORD

Dear Student,

Rwanda Basic Education Board is honoured to present to you History book for Senior Four for Languages Pathway which serves as a guide to competence-based teaching and learning to ensure consistency and coherence in the learning of History subject. The Rwandan educational philosophy is to ensure that you achieve full potential at every level of education, which will prepare you to be well integrated in society and exploit employment opportunities.

The government of Rwanda emphasises the importance of aligning teaching and learning materials with the syllabus to facilitate your learning process. Many factors influence what you learn, how well you learn and the competence you acquire. Those factors include quality instructional materials available, assessment strategies for the students among others. Special attention was paid to activities that facilitate learning process, develop your ideas and make new discoveries during concrete activities carried out individually or with peers.

In competence-based curriculum, the student considers learning as a process of active building and developing knowledge and meanings where concepts are mainly introduced by an activity, a situation or a scenario that helps the student to construct knowledge, develop skills and acquire positive attitudes and values. For effective use of this textbook, your role is to:

- Work on given activities which lead to the development of skills
- Share relevant information with other students through presentations, discussions, group work and other active learning techniques such as role play, case studies, investigation and research in the library, from the internet or from your community;
- Participate and take responsibility for your own learning;
- Draw conclusions based on the findings from the learning activities.

To facilitate you in doing activities, the content of this book is self-explanatory so that you can easily use it by yourself, acquire and assess your competences. The book is made of units whereby each unit comprises: the key unit competence, followed by the introductory activity before the development of History concepts that are connected to real world situation.

I wish to sincerely extend my appreciation to REB staff who organized the editing process of this textbook. Special gratitude also goes to lecturers, educational patterners, teachers, illustrators and designers who supported the exercise throughout. Any comment or contribution would be welcome to the improvement of this textbook for the next edition.

Dr. MBARUSHIMANA Nelson

Director General / REB



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Joan Murungi

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UNIT 1

GENERAL INTRODUCTION TO THE HISTORY OF PRECOLONIAL RWANDA



Fig. 1.1: King's palace in Nyanza. Photo by Guswen, CC BY 3.0



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse the origins, expansion, social, cultural, economic, political and military organization of precolonial Rwanda in order to appreciate the historical foundations of the Rwandan nation.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, learners should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Describe the meaning, relevance and importance of history in today's life.
- Explain how historical information on precolonial Rwanda is collected and interpreted.
- Explain the formation, expansion and decline of the Rwandan kingdom.
- Describe the social, cultural, political, economic and military organization of precolonial Rwanda.
- Identify key monarchs who contributed to the expansion of Rwanda and state their major achievements.

Skills

2

- Evaluate the importance of history in comparison with other sciences and social studies.
- Analyse different sources of historical information on precolonial Rwanda and judge their strengths and limitations.
- Examine how social, cultural, economic, political and military organization of precolonial Rwanda shaped the development of precolonial Rwanda.
- Draw lessons from precolonial Rwanda that can strengthen patriotism, unity and responsible citizenship today.

Attitudes and Values

3

- Advocate for the study of history among peers.
- Appreciate the different sources through which the history of precolonial Rwanda is collected-
- Value the social, cultural, economic, political and military organization of precolonial Rwanda that contributed to the growth of Rwanda.
- Respect Rwanda's cultural heritage and historical sites.
- Reject divisive and biased interpretations of Rwandan history.

Introduction

This unit introduces the History of Rwanda by exploring how we know what happened in the past. It explains that, since much of precolonial Rwanda was not written down, historians reconstruct the past through oral traditions, material evidence, later written accounts, and audiovisual records.

The unit also presents the formation and expansion of the Rwandan kingdom, the institutions that shaped political and social life, and the cultural values of precolonial society. It encourages students to read history critically, especially older interpretations influenced by colonial bias and divisive ideology.

Above all, it shows that Rwanda existed long before colonization, with its own systems of governance, defense, culture, production, and social organization that built a shared national heritage.

Key words and concepts:

- History
- Precolonial Rwanda
- Historical sources
- Oral tradition
- Archaeology
- Monarchy
- Ubwiru
- Itorero
- Patriotism
- Bias

Introductory activity 1



Instructions: Discuss the questions, write brief answers, and prepare to present your ideas to the class.

Scenario:

Your class visits a former royal site. On the hill, you see pottery fragments, an old path leading to a spring, an elder reciting a dynastic poem, and a museum display showing photographs and royal objects. A student asks, "Which of these things can really help us know the history of precolonial Rwanda?"

Questions:

1. From the items observed at the site, identify which ones are sources of history and explain what each source can tell us.
2. Why is it dangerous to rely on only one source when reconstructing the history of precolonial Rwanda?
3. What is the importance of studying precolonial Rwanda for a student living in Rwanda today?

1.1 Why do we study history?

Learning activity 1.1



Instructions:

Read the scenario carefully, then discuss and answer in full sentences using examples from school, community life and the history of Rwanda.

Scenario:

Some students say that history only talks about things that happened long ago and therefore has little value today. Others argue that history helps citizens make better decisions in the present.

Questions:

1. What arguments would you give to show that history is useful in today's life?
2. In what ways can the study of history protect society from manipulation, prejudice and conflict?

History is the study of past human activities, institutions, ideas and experiences on the basis of evidence. It is not simply a list of dates and names. Rather, it is a disciplined attempt to understand change over time, continuity, causes, consequences and the choices made by people in the past.

When historians study the past, they do not only ask what happened. They also ask why it happened, how it happened, who was involved, what changed, what remained constant, and how the past continues to influence the present.

For students in Rwanda, history is especially important because it helps them to understand the country's roots, institutions, values and transformations. It shows that Rwanda has a long historical experience that began long before colonial rule.

History is therefore important in everyday life for several reasons:

- History helps people to understand their identity, heritage and national values.
- History promotes patriotism, respect for heritage and a sense of belonging to the nation.
- History develops the ability to question, compare, interpret and judge evidence.
- History strengthens critical thinking by teaching students to analyse sources and question bias.
- History helps citizens to recognize the causes of conflict, division and injustice, and to avoid repeating them.
- History supports good leadership and planning because societies can learn from past successes and failures.
- History prepares us for the future, after we have known the present
- History is a career subject. Through it, we can become teachers, lawyers, administrators, curators and politicians.
- History promotes moral principles through the study of personalities with high moral standards.
- History helps to promote international understanding among nations and people.
- History helps us to be tolerant by learning about culture and values of different tribes and races. This is important in the promotion of mutual understanding, tolerance and peaceful co-existence

Compared with other sciences, history focuses particularly on the human past and on interpretation of evidence over time. It shares tools with other disciplines, but its special strength lies in explaining how and why societies change. A scientific subject may explain how iron is formed, for example, while history asks who used iron, how it affected production, and what it changed in society.

In the Languages pathway, history also develops reading, writing, speaking, analysis and interpretation skills. Students read sources carefully, compare narratives, debate ideas and communicate arguments clearly. For this reason, history contributes not only to knowledge, but also to language mastery and citizenship education

Application activity 1.1



Instructions: Discuss the questions and share your conclusions with the class

Scenario: During a classroom discussion, a teacher asks students to think about how past events influence their lives today. One student talk about how learning about Rwanda's past helps them to feel proud of their country. Another explains that studying previous conflicts teaches people to make better decisions and avoid division. The teacher then asks them to compare history with science, and students note that while science explains natural processes, history focuses on people's actions and their effects on society.

Questions:

1. From the scenario, how does studying the past help students develop a sense of national identity?
2. What lesson can students learn from past conflicts, and how can it influence their decisions today?
3. Based on the discussion, how is history different from science in the way it explains events?

1.2 Sources of historical information on precolonial Rwanda

Learning activity 1.2



Instructions:

Classify the evidence, explain your reasons, and share your conclusions with the class.

Scenario:

A historian wants to write about precolonial Rwanda. She has oral testimonies from elders, royal poems, old hoes and pottery from archaeological sites, a missionary record written in the colonial period, and photographs are later collected by a museum.

Questions:

1. Classify these materials into the main sources of history.
2. Which source would be most useful for understanding daily life in old Rwanda? Explain your answer.
3. Why must written colonial accounts be read critically when studying precolonial Rwanda?

Sources of historical information on precolonial Rwanda are material sources (archeological), oral sources, written sources and audiovisual sources. Each type provides valuable information, but none can explain the past fully on its own, so it is better when they are used together.

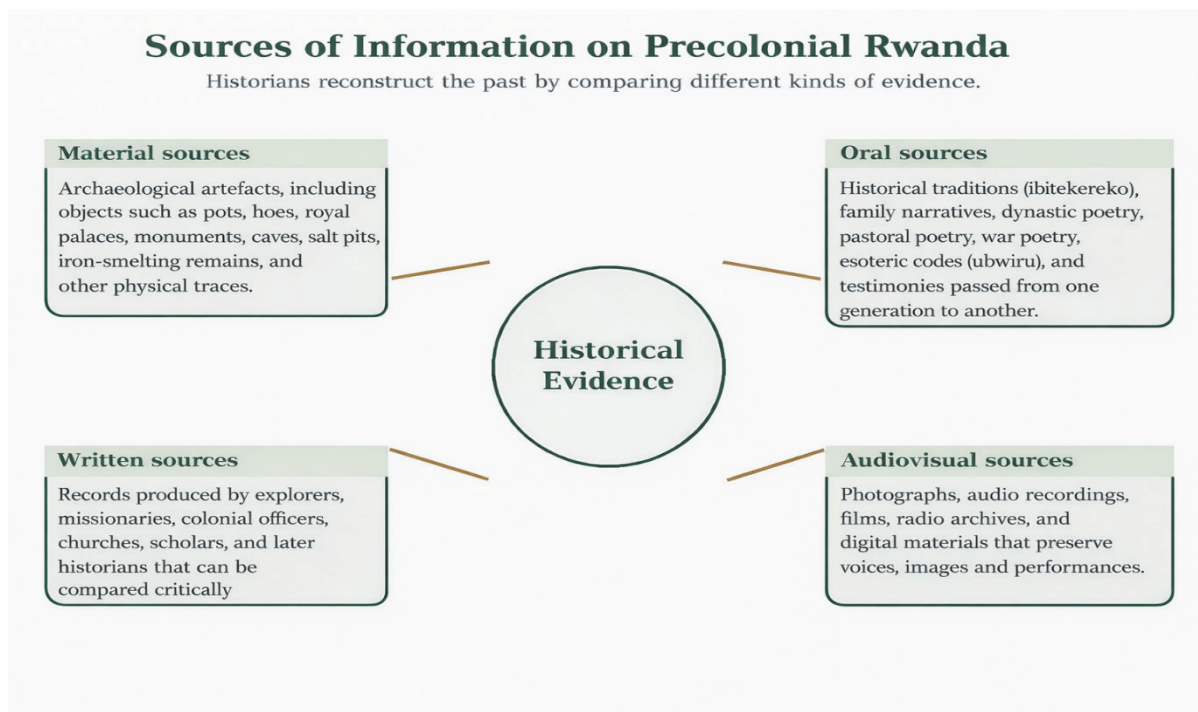


Fig. 1.2: Main sources used in getting information on history of precolonial Rwanda.

Oral sources



Fig. 1.3: Oral tradition as a source of History

They are very crucial for the study of precolonial Rwanda, where history was mainly transmitted by word of mouth. They come from people's memories, stories and verbal traditions passed down over time. They preserve memory and values but must be compared carefully because accounts may differ.

Oral sources include:

- **Genealogies** that were divided into dynastic and family genealogies. Dynastic genealogy (ubucurabwenge) was carefully transmitted orally by genealogists

called Abacurabwenge, who preserved the names and royal titles of Rwandan kings, making it an important source for the chronology of Rwanda's history. Family genealogy helped to complete this chronology and enabled individuals and families to identify themselves within the community.

- **Esoteric code (ubwiru)** that was the text which was exclusively for the "abiru" who were special advisors to the King. It includes royal secrets, all the rules and application of these rules relating to the royal institution. The "ubwiru" texts were rituals, which were learnt by heart by the "abiru".
- **Poems and songs** were important sources of historical information in ancient Rwanda. Poetry was transmitted orally and included dynastic poetry (ibisigo), pastoral poetry (amahamba or amazina y'inka), and warrior poetry (ibyvugo). Traditional songs and dances were performed during festivals, weddings, naming ceremonies, and other social events. Examples include the Intore dance, which celebrated bravery, and amahigi, which was related to hunting activities. Other folk songs included ibihozo (choral songs), indirimbo z'ingabo (warriors' songs), and amasare (wrestling songs).
- **Historical stories** (ibitekerezo) that included official, popular, and familiar stories. Official stories were carefully transmitted through the royal court by people who learned them systematically from their parents or neighbors, and they presented selected historical events approved by the monarchy. Popular stories were transmitted more freely among the people and included legends, tales (imigani miremire), proverbs (imigani migufi), and riddles (ibisakuzo). Familiar stories were private family or community narratives and are considered important because they were less likely to be manipulated, making them valuable sources of Rwandan history.

Archaeological sources

They include physical remains from the past, such as pottery, hoes, iron-smelting remains, hunting and fishing tools, caves, royal palaces, monuments, salt pits and other historic sites. Some were found in the archeological sites while others were found in the community. They are usually kept in museums and they help historians to understand production, technology, settlement, social organization and cultural practices.

Written sources

Although few written records existed before colonization, they became more common from the late nineteenth century. Some information about precolonial Rwanda, was later recorded by missionaries, explorers, colonial administrators, and scholars including Rwandan scholars such as Alexis Kagame.

Audio-visual(electronic) sources

In historical studies of precolonial Rwanda, audio-visual sources are usually considered supplementary sources that support oral traditions, archaeology, and written records. Old photographs and early films taken during the late 19th and early 20th centuries (during the German and Belgian colonial periods) captured some aspects of Rwanda that still reflected precolonial traditions and institutions. They help historians understand aspects of Rwandan life such as traditional huts (*inzu*), royal

palaces, kings and chiefs, culture, Intore dances, drumming ceremonies, farming and herding activities, as well as clothing and ornaments. They also provide visual evidence of historical figures like King Yuhi V Musinga and King Mutara III Rudahigwa

Table 1.1: Strengths and limitations of sources of information on precolonial Rwanda

Sources	Examples	Strengths	Limitations
Oral	Historical stories, genealogies, esoteric code, poetry and songs	Preserves local traditions and culture, useful where written records are absent, provides eyewitness accounts	Memory loss or distortion over time, subject to bias and exaggeration, difficult to verify accuracy, lacks exact dates and chronology
Archeology	Artefacts, monuments and royal sites	Provides physical and tangible evidence of the past, useful for studying ancient societies without written records, helps reconstruct early human life and culture	Interpretation can be uncertain, difficult to date without experts, excavation is expensive and time-consuming, does not clearly explain reasons behind events
Written	Accounts by explorers, missionaries, colonial officers, church records, reports and later scholars	Provides detailed and permanent records, can be stored, offers chronological information, useful for research and verification, covers wide range of topics	-May reflect bias (especially colonial writers), some documents may be lost or incomplete or easily destroyed, limited access to archives or library, language barrier
Audio-visual	Photographs	Provide visual evidence of past events, help in understanding appearance of people, places, and events, help keep memory of traditional practices, easy to interpret compared other sources, can support other sources of history.	Can be manipulated, capture only a single moment, not full context, can be misinterpreted, old photos and recordings may be damaged or lost.

A good historian compares sources instead of accepting one source blindly. For example, an oral narrative can be checked against archaeology, while a written account can be tested against local traditions and museum evidence. This critical method is very important when studying precolonial Rwanda.

Students should therefore avoid two mistakes: first, assuming that only written sources are reliable; and second, assuming that every traditional narrative is literally true in all its details. Historical knowledge grows stronger when sources are compared, questioned and interpreted carefully.

Application activity 1.2



1. Why might historians not rely on only one type of source when reconstructing Rwanda's history? Give a reason.
2. If two sources give different versions of the same historical event, what should a historian do to reach a reliable conclusion?
3. How can a historian determine whether a historical source is trustworthy or not?

1.3 Formation, expansion and decline of the Rwandan kingdom

Learning activity 1.3



Instructions:

Discuss the question as if you were advisors to the court and justify your recommendations.

Scenario:

Imagine you are an advisor at the royal court during a period when Rwanda is surrounded by rival kingdoms. The king wants to know whether he should expand territory through diplomacy, marriage alliances, military organization, or a combination of methods.

Questions:

1. What reasons might lead a kingdom to expand?
2. Why did strong leadership and disciplined military organization matter in the growth of Rwanda?

The Rwandan kingdom was not formed in one day. It grew gradually through consolidation, conquest and the strengthening of royal institutions. In the historical tradition, Rwanda kingdom started at Gasabo in Buganza, and it is often presented as a kingdom with a strong sense of territorial expansion and political unity. Over time, it extended its influence over neighboring regions and built a more centralized form of rule.

The expansion of the Kingdom of Rwanda was supported by several important factors such as:

- Rwanda possessed a well-organized and well-equipped army composed of physically fit and loyal men who were committed to serving the kingdom.

- Its small size that made it easier to control and administer effectively.
- Weak neighboring kingdoms such as Buliza, Nduga, and Bumbogo were relatively weak, making them easier to conquer. The kingdom had a strong political organization that strengthened central authority and protected it from attacks.
- Cultural unity among Rwandans also played a major role since the people shared the same language, culture, and religious beliefs, which promoted cooperation and solidarity.
- Rwanda was further blessed with able and powerful leaders such as King Cyirima Rujugira, who introduced many administrative and military innovations.
- Patriotism also contributed to expansion; for example, King Rwabugiri defended the kingdom's interests by refusing to cooperate with slave traders such as Rumliza, an agent of Tip Tip.
- Marriage alliances also helped the kingdom expand peacefully in some cases, such as the conquest of Nduga through the marriage of Nyirantorwa, daughter of Mibambwe I Sekarongoro, to Mashira, the king of Nduga.
- Soldiers were motivated by rewards after war, including gifts such as umudende, Impotore, and Gucana uruti, which encouraged bravery in battle.
- The kingdom also benefited from war loot (iminyago), which increased its wealth.
- Trade and exchange with neighboring kingdoms strengthened the economy, including the exchange of commodities such as salt from Lake Katwe in Uganda.
- Fertile soil and a favorable climate supported agriculture and animal rearing, enabling the kingdom to provide enough food for both the population and the army.

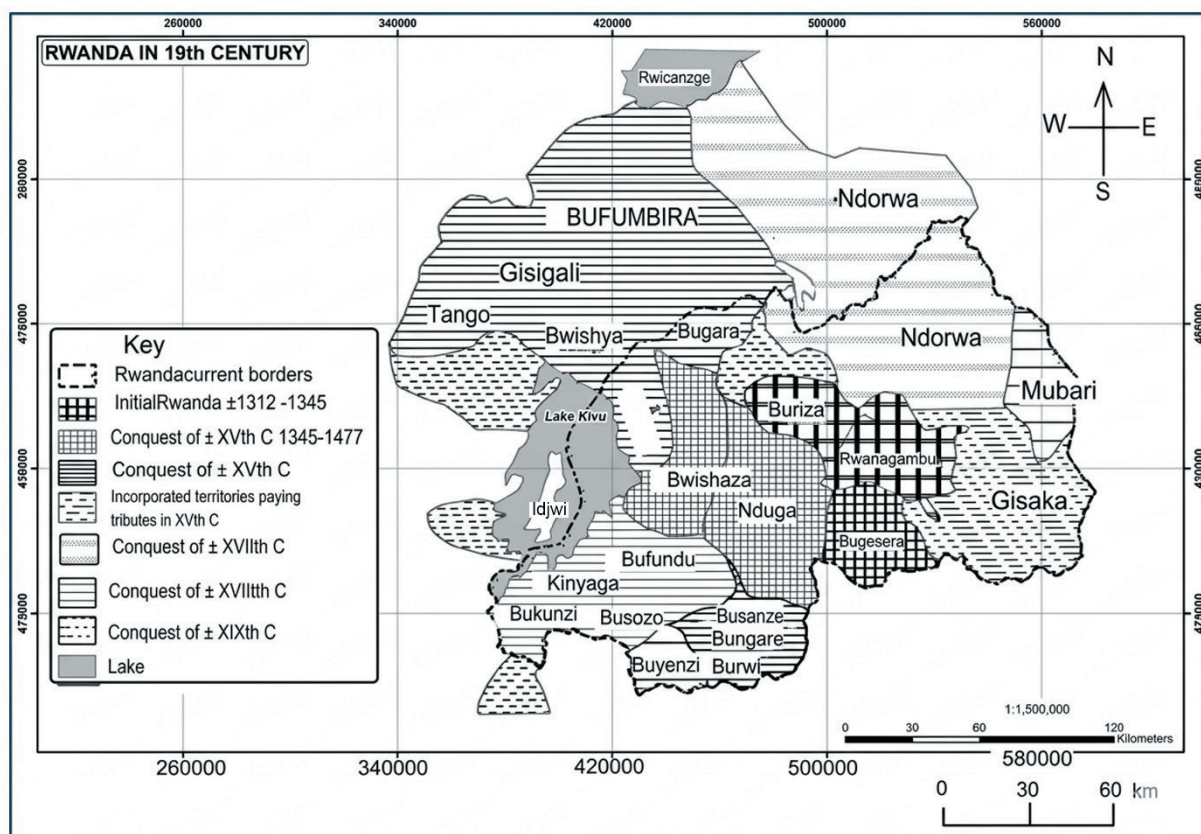


Fig. 1.4: Rwanda at the end of the 19th century after centuries of expansion (adapted from *History of Rwanda / Lugan 1997*)

Table 1.2: Selected monarchs and their major achievements for expanding and protecting the borders of Rwanda

Monarch	Dates	Major achievements
Ruganzu I Bwimba	1312–1345	Capital at Gasabo; expanded Rwanda by annexing areas such as Bwanacyambwe, Buriza, Busigi and Busarasi (later Bumbogo) and played an important role in struggles involving Gisaka.
Kigeli I Mukobanya	1378–1411	Fought territories of North of Nduga; defended Rwanda when Gisaka and Bunyoro threatened the kingdom; Rwanda's capital shifted toward Nduga during this period.
Ruganzu II Ndoli	1510–1543	Reunified Rwanda; restored the kingdom's symbols, with Karinga replacing Rwoga; revived and strengthened <i>ubwiru</i> ; built up itorero and reasserted royal authority.
Cyirima II Rujugira	1675–1708	Established permanent military camps (<i>ingerero</i>), strengthened frontier defense and military strategy, and deepened the spirit of territorial protection and conquest.
Kigeli III Ndabarasa	1708–1741	Recovered Ndorwa and consolidated royal authority in contested regions.
Yuhi IV Gahindiro	1746–1802	Became king when still young; regency under Nyiritunga showed the political importance of women; cultural life developed, including famous traditions of naming cattle.
Mutara II Rwogera	1802–1853	Rwanda's sovereignty was defended during attacks from Burundi; Queen mother Nyiramavugo Nyiramongi is remembered for protecting the kingdom while the king was still young.
Kigeli IV Rwabugiri	1853–1896	Greatly expanded and centralized Rwanda; strengthened the administrative system and is remembered as one of the most powerful precolonial kings.

The decline of the precolonial Kingdom of Rwanda began in the late nineteenth century and was caused by a combination of internal conflicts, colonial intervention, and economic difficulties such as:

- Continuous wars against neighboring kingdoms, especially during the reign of Kigeli IV Rwabugiri, caused heavy losses of experienced soldiers and weakened the military strength of Rwanda.
- The large size of the kingdom during the reign of Kigeli IV Rwabugiri made it increasingly difficult to control effectively.
- Economic decline also contributed to the downfall of the kingdom, as prolonged

droughts and famines such as Rukungugu, Ruyaga, and Rumanura disrupted agricultural production and affected the wellbeing of the population.

- After the death of King Kigeli IV Rwabugiri in 1895, the kingdom experienced a serious succession crisis that culminated in the Rucunshu coup d'état of 1896. These succession disputes created disunity among Rwandans, weakened the monarchy, and undermined political stability. This was followed by several revolts and rejection of Musinga as king: organized by Rukara, Basebya, Ndungutse, and Nyiragahumuza further weakened the kingdom.
- The arrival of Europeans and the colonization of Rwanda further accelerated the decline, as Rwanda became a German protectorate in 1897 and later came under Belgian rule from 1916. Belgian colonial reforms greatly reduced the authority of the king and abolished important traditional institutions such as ubwiru and umuganura.
- The death of capable leaders such as MUTARA III RUDAHIGWA contributed to the collapse of strong leadership and eventually paved the way for the replacement of the monarchy by the republic.

The decline of precolonial Rwanda should therefore be understood not as the disappearance of all Rwandan institutions, but as a period in which succession conflict, changing power relations and the coming of Europeans transformed the kingdom and opened the way to colonial rule and later on to the Republic.

Application activity 1.3



1. How did factors such as security needs, control of resources, and royal prestige influence the expansion of the Rwandan kingdom?
2. In what ways did the map of expanded Rwanda help historians and students understand the long process of kingdom formation?
3. Why did internal political instability make the Rwandan kingdom more vulnerable to colonial intervention?

1.4 Political and military organisation of precolonial Rwanda

Learning activity 1.4



Instructions: Read the scenario and answer related questions

Scenario:

A student says that a kingdom can only remain strong if it has both leadership and institutions. Another student says that military power alone is enough.

Questions:

1. What political institutions helped the king rule Rwanda effectively?
2. How did "itorero" and the army contribute not only to warfare but also to discipline and patriotism?

The political organisation of precolonial Rwanda became increasingly centralized, especially in the nineteenth century at the top stood the king, who symbolized unity, legitimacy and authority. The monarchy was bio cephalous in the sense that the queen mother also played an important role in political life. The royal court was therefore not only a residence, but also of government, ritual and administration. It also included important personalities such as the Abiru, the custodians of royal esoteric code and succession procedures. Institutions such as Ubwiru, Ubucurabwenge and dynastic poetry helped preserve the memory, legitimacy and ritual order of the monarchy.

Furthermore, the kingdom of Rwanda was divided into "Ibiti" or Districts which were large constituencies covering several hills and villages. These "ibiti" were headed by great chiefs (Abatware b'intebe) appointed by the king and lived most of their lives in the royal court. They were consulted by the king especially in the time of crises and maintained communication between the royal court and the local population. These "Ibiti" were divided into "Ibikingi" which were a collection of different hills where administrative authority was exercised by three chiefs: chief land (Umutware w' ubutaka) who was in charge of agricultural production and responsible for collecting royal tribute, "ikoro" from agricultural production, chief of cattle (Umutware w'umukenke) who was responsible for pastures and collected tax dues from cattle keepers and chief of army (Umutware w'ingabo) who commanded the army and participating in protecting and expanding the kingdom.

Military organization was one of the pillars of the kingdom. The army defended borders, supported expansion, maintained order and protected the kingdom from rival states. Young people were trained in Itorero institution which was not merely a school for war but it also trained youth in discipline, courage, loyalty, and civic values. Many regiments (*imitwe y'ingabo*) drew their strength from this broader culture of education and socialization. In this way, military organization was linked to patriotism, discipline, collective responsibility and the quality of being a man.

Political and Military Organization of Precolonial Rwanda

Simplified overview of the main institutions of the kingdom

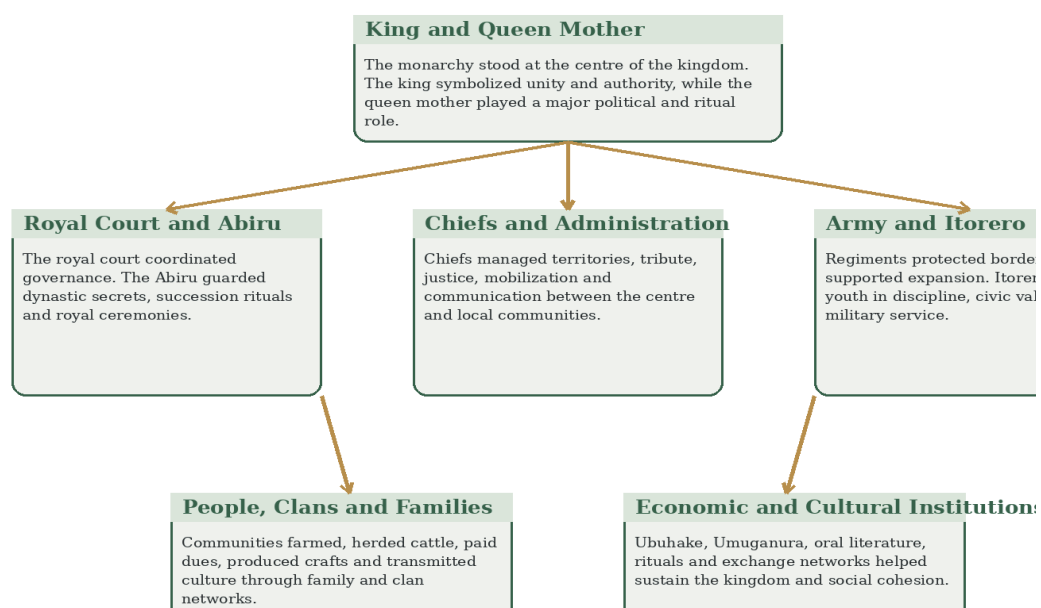


Fig. 1.5: Simplified view of the main political and military institutions of precolonial Rwanda.

Main features of political and military organization included:

- A centralized monarchy headed by the king "umwami" and queen-mother (umugabekazi),
- The royal court as the centre of ritual, administration and decision-making,
- The Abiru as guardians of royal traditions, succession and sacred knowledge,
- Great chiefs and local chiefs who linked the centre to the population
- Regiments (*imitwe y'ingabo*) that protected borders and supported expansion
- *Itorero* as an institution of civic, moral and military formation

Application activity 1.4



1. How did institutions such as Ubwiru and the Abiru help preserve the authority and traditions of the Rwandan monarchy?
2. In what ways did military organization contribute not only to defense but also to the expansion and stability of the kingdom?
3. Why can the Itorero institution be seen as both a military and a civic education system in precolonial Rwanda?

1.5 Social, cultural and economic organization of precolonial Rwanda

Learning activity 1.5



Instructions:

Discuss the statement and use examples from the lesson to show the relationship between institutions and everyday life.

Scenario:

In a classroom discussion, one student argues that precolonial Rwanda should only be studied politically. Another says that to understand a society fully, we must also study how people lived, worked, celebrated, believed and related to one another.

Questions:

1. Why is it necessary to study social, cultural and economic life together with politics?
2. What values and practices that helped to hold precolonial Rwandan society together?

Socially, the Kingdom of Rwanda had an organized social structure. The smallest social unit was the family (*Inzu*). This was followed by a larger unit called the lineage (*Umuryango*), which consisted of several families that shared a common ancestor. From the lineage, the social

organisation expanded into a clan (*Ubwoko*) that shared the same totem. Examples of clans are abanyiginya, abasinga, abasindi, abaha, abega, abazigaba, abagesera, abakono, ababanda and abacyaba.

Its social organization was based on kinship, clan identity, household life, reciprocity, respect for elders and marriage among people. Before colonial manipulation hardened social identities, society was held together by a shared language, common institutions, and strong interdependence.

Culturally, pre-colonial Rwanda was rich in oral literature that included tales (*imigani miremire*), proverbs, riddles and poems, rituals, poetry, dance, music, rites such as naming and death ceremonies and taboos. *Umuganura* symbolised the link between political authority, fertility, harvest, and the well-being of the population, while traditions such as *amazina y'inka* (cattle poems), dynastic poetry, and historical narratives preserved memory and identity.

Mode of food and drinks, mode of dressing, mode of dancing(intore), division of labour among people, religion and belief also shaped life. People believed in *Imana y'i Rwanda* and observed rituals such as "kuraguza", "Guterekera" and "Kubandwa" connected to kingship, fertility, rain, cattle, and harvest. The royal court had an important ceremonial role, but cultural life was also rooted in the family, community, and clan.

Rites such as "child naming" (*gusohora umwana*), taboos(*kirazira*) were also observed.



Fig. 1.6. Naming a child

Economically, Rwanda depended on agriculture, cattle-keeping, handcraft production including pottery, cloth making, iron smelting, wood tool-making, weaving. Other activities including bee-keeping and exchange (barter trade).

Cattle were valued economically, socially, and symbolically. Institutions such as “*Ubugake*” further shaped social and economic relations by linking patrons and clients through cattle-based obligations.

Table 1.3: Overview of the organization of precolonial Rwanda

Aspect	Key characteristics
Social	Rwandan society was divided into families, lineages and clans. Its social organization was based on kinship, clan identity, household life, reciprocity, respect for elders and marriage among people. Society was held together by a shared language, common institutions, and strong interdependence.
Cultural	Oral literature, poetry, music, dance, rituals, royal ceremonies, rites and taboos, mode of food, mode of dressing, and “ <i>umuganura</i> ” preserved identity and values.
Economic	Agriculture, cattle-keeping, iron-working, pottery, bee-keeping, exchange and tribute sustained society and the kingdom.
Political	The king, queen mother, Abiru and chiefs formed the main framework of governance.
Military	Regiments (<i>imitwe y’ingabo</i>), frontier camps (<i>ingerero</i>) and Itorero helped defend the kingdom and support expansion.

Application activity 1.5



1. How did social structures such as families, clans, and mutual assistance contribute to unity and stability in precolonial Rwandan society?
2. In what ways did economic activities like agriculture, cattle-keeping, and craft production support both daily life and the functioning of the kingdom?
3. How did the political organization involving the king, queen mother, chiefs, and Abiru ensure effective governance and continuity in precolonial Rwanda?

1.6 End of unit assessment

Summative assessment 1

Instructions:

Answer all questions clearly. Use simple and correct terms. Give examples where necessary.

Questions:

Section A. Knowledge and understanding

1. Define history and state one importance of studying history.
2. Name four main sources of historical information on precolonial Rwanda.
3. Why should historians compare different sources when reconstructing the past?
4. State two limitations of oral sources.

Section B. Skills

5. Compare oral sources and written sources. Give one strength and one limitation of each.
6. Show how Itorero contributed to the development of precolonial Rwanda beyond warfare.

Section C. Attitudes and values

7. Why is it important for students in Rwanda today to study the history of precolonial Rwanda?
8. Why should divisive and biased interpretations of Rwandan history be rejected?

References

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UNIT 2

ROLE OF COLONIAL AGENTS IN THE COLONISATION OF AFRICA



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse the role of various colonial agents in the colonization of Africa and assess their impact on African societies for the spirit of patriotism.

Fig. 2.1: An imagined scene showing explorers, missionaries, traders and colonial officials opening the way for European occupation of Africa.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, learners should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- 1
 - Identify the main colonial agents and their activities in Africa.
 - Explain how explorers, missionaries, traders, chartered companies and administrators helped to prepare the way for colonial rule.
 - Describe the problems faced by colonial agents in Africa.
 - Explain the political, social, cultural and economic effects of colonial agents on African societies.
 - Describe the scramble and partition of Africa and their impact.

Skills

- 2
 - Analyse the activities of different colonial agents in Africa.
 - Assess the roles played by colonial agents during the colonization process.
 - Examine the problems they faced and the effects of their activities.
 - Analyse the scramble for Africa and the consequences of partition.

Attitudes and Values

3

- Recognize colonial agents as an important part of the history of African colonization.
- Read colonial history critically and appreciate African sovereignty, patriotism and unity.
- Acknowledge the harmful legacy of colonialism while valuing efforts that promote peace and national cohesion.

Introduction

European colonization of Africa was not a single sudden event. Even before, direct political control was imposed, different colonial agents had already entered many parts of the continent. Explorers mapped rivers, routes and resources; missionaries spread Christianity and western education; traders and chartered companies expanded commercial influence; and administrators later organized formal colonial rule.

Together, these agents weakened African sovereignty and helped European powers occupy African territories. This unit examines their activities, the roles they played, the problems they faced, the effects they produced, and the scramble and partition of Africa.

Key words and concepts:

- Colonial agents
- Imperialism
- Chartered company
- Protectorate
- Effective occupation
- Scramble
- Partition
- Artificial boundaries

Introductory activity 2



Instructions:

Work in pairs or small groups. Discuss the questions, write brief answers, and prepare to share your ideas with the class.

Scenario:

Before foreign rule is declared, an African kingdom receives visitors carrying maps, Bibles, medicine, trade goods and written agreements. They promise friendship, knowledge and commerce. A few years later, foreign influence grows, local authority weakens and the territory is claimed by a European power.

Questions:

1. Why might African leaders and communities welcome such visitors at first?
2. How could mapping, missionary work and trade all help to prepare the way for colonization?
3. Why was it dangerous to sign treaties or concessions without fully understanding them?
4. What lesson does this situation teach about sovereignty and foreign influence?

2.1 Colonial agents and their activities in Africa

Learning activity 1.5



Read the story and answer to related questions

Short Story: "The Changing Land"

In the late 19th century, European explorers arrived in Africa searching for rivers, trade routes, and geographical knowledge. They mapped unknown areas and reported valuable resources back to Europe. Soon after, missionaries came to spread Christianity, build churches, schools, and hospitals, and teach Western education. Traders followed, looking for raw materials such as ivory, gold, rubber, and later agricultural products. They established trading posts along the coasts and inland areas. Although these groups claimed to bring civilization, religion, and commerce, their activities also opened the way for European colonial rule and foreign control over African societies.

Questions

1. what were the main activities of explorers, missionaries and traders?
2. Why did local leaders lose control over their territory?
3. What do you understand by the "colonial agents"?

Colonial agents were individuals or organizations that entered Africa before or during the period of formal colonial rule and opened the way for European colonial rule and foreign control over African societies. They belonged to different categories and used different methods depending on their aims and background. Although they did not all operate in the same way, their activities often complemented one another and together they increased foreign influence in many parts of Africa.

2.1.1 Explorers and travelers

Explorers and travelers were people who moved through different parts of Africa in order to discover, observe and record information about the continent. They travelled across rivers, lakes, forests, mountains and political centers while studying the geography, peoples, resources and systems of government they found.

Their main activities included mapping routes, describing landscapes, identifying important places and writing reports about trade, culture and political organization. Some travelled for scientific discovery, while others were interested in learning more about commerce and communication routes. Examples include Mungo Park, who explored the Niger River, Speke and Grant, who reached the Nile region, and Henry Morton Stanley, who travelled through the Congo Basin.

Mungo Park

Mungo Park (1771–1806), a Scottish surgeon trained at Edinburgh, entered West Africa in 1795 under the sponsorship of the African Association to discover the course of the Niger River and improve European geographical knowledge of the interior. Travelling from the Gambia through Kaarta and other inland territories, he reached the Niger at Ségou in 1796 and proved that the river flowed eastward, a major result because Europeans had long debated its direction.

Park returned on a second expedition in 1805 with about forty-five Europeans and attempted to descend the river toward the coast, but disease, lack food, exhaustion and conflict devastated the party and in 1806 near Bussa Rapids, his boat was attacked by local people. Mungo Park and most of his companions drowned while trying to escape. His journeys gave Britain clearer knowledge of the Niger basin, encouraged later expeditions and trade, and helped to make the region later become more attractive to British commercial and imperial interests.

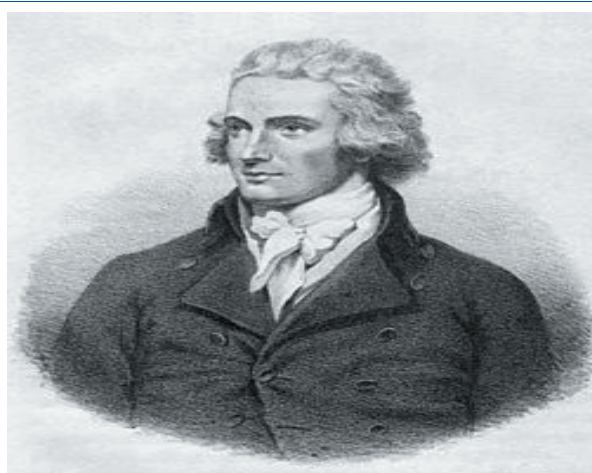


Fig. 2.2 (a): Posthumous portrait of Mungo Park, the Scottish explorer of the Niger.

Approximate route of Mungo Park in West Africa, 1795–1797 and 1805–1806.



Fig. 2.2(b): Approximate route of Mungo Park in West Africa, 1795–1797 and 1805–1806.

Heinrich Barth

Johann Heinrich Barth (1821–1865), a German scholar, linguist and explorer attached to a British-sponsored expedition, entered Africa in 1849 to explore Saharan trade routes, gather scientific information and assess commercial possibilities in the western Sudan.

Between 1849 and 1855, he crossed the Sahara from Tripoli, travelled through Agadez and Bornu, and eventually reached Timbuktu, while compiling unusually detailed observations on politics, languages, oral traditions and regional history.

After the deaths of two European colleagues, Barth continued much of the expedition with African assistance, showing both the hardship of the journey and the importance of local intermediaries.

The main result of his travels was a rich body of geographical and ethnographic knowledge that later became useful not only to scholars but also to European merchants and colonial planners. In this way, his work indirectly contributed to later imperial interest in the interior of Africa and the Sahel.



Fig. 2.3 (a): Portrait of Heinrich Barth, German explorer and scholar of Africa.

Approximate route of Heinrich Barth across the Sahara and western Sudan, 1849–1855.

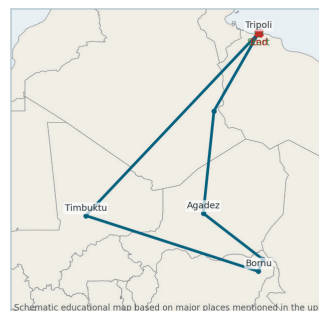


Fig. 2.3 (b): Approximate route of Heinrich Barth across the Sahara and western Sudan, 1849–1855.

John Hanning Speke

John Hanning Speke (1827–1864), an English army officer and explorer, came to East Africa in 1856 with Richard Burton after the Royal Geographical Society chose them to search for the source of the Nile. On their first expedition of 1856–1859, they travelled inland from Zanzibar to Tabora and Lake Tanganyika. Although illness limited their progress, Speke eventually pushed northwards and in 1858 saw Lake Victoria, identifying it as the source of the Nile.

On the second expedition from 1860 to 1863, Speke and James Grant moved around Lake Victoria, reached Buganda, and identified the point where the Nile leaves the lake near modern Jinja.

The result of these journeys was to focus European attention on the Great Lakes region and to provide reports that increased British political and missionary interest in Buganda and neighbouring territories. Thus, although Speke travelled as an explorer, his discoveries helped to prepare the ground for later British influence in Uganda.



Approximate route of Speke's East African expeditions, 1856–1859 and 1860–1863.

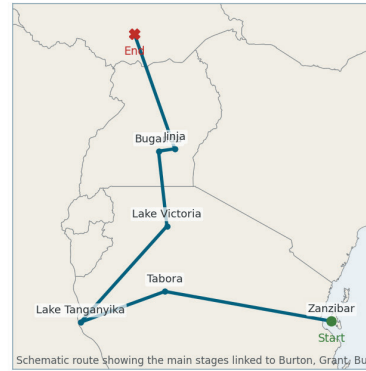


Fig. 2.4(a): John Hanning Speke, associated with the search for the source of the Nile.

Fig. 2.4 (b): Approximate route of Speke's East Africa expeditions, 1856–1859 and 1860–1863.

Henry Morton Stanley

Henry Morton Stanley (1841–1904), a Welsh-American journalist, first entered Africa in 1871 to find David Livingstone for the New York Herald, and his later journeys turned him into one of the most consequential colonial agents in central Africa.

After locating Livingstone at Ujiji in 1871, Stanley returned to Africa in 1874–1877, crossed the continent from the East African coast to the Atlantic, charted the Congo River and confirmed that the Congo basin could be penetrated by river and overland routes.

Henry Morton Stanley is the first Whiteman who tried to enter Rwanda as he reached *Ihema* island in March 1876. Between 1897 and 1884 he worked directly for King Leopold II, building roads and stations, negotiating treaties and laying the operational foundations of Leopold's Congo enterprise.

Facing illness, violent confrontations and severe logistical challenges, Stanley became known for harsh methods. His work had immediate impact: transforming exploration into occupation and directly enabling the establishment of colonial rule in the Congo Free State.



Fig. 2.5 (a): Portrait of Henry Morton Stanley in the 1870s.



Fig. 2.5 (b): Approximate route of Stanley's major central African journeys, 1871–1877 and 1879–1884.

2.1.2 Missionaries

Missionaries were religious men and women who came to Africa mainly to spread Christianity and western education. Their activities included preaching the Christian faith, establishing churches, opening schools and health centres, translating some African languages, and teaching reading and writing.

Many missionaries also campaigned against the slave trade and introduced new religious and social teachings. In the course of their work, they often criticized certain African beliefs and customs as they claimed to promote Christian values and ways of life.

David Livingstone

David Livingstone (1813–1873), a Scottish doctor and missionary associated with the London Missionary Society, entered southern Africa in 1841 with the aim of spreading Christianity, promoting what he called “commerce and civilization,” and challenging the slave trade.

During the 1850s, he crossed from the interior to the west coast at Luanda and then to the east coast at Quelimane, publicised the Zambezi region and later explored central African lakes and river systems up to his death at Chitambo, Zambia in 1873.

Livingstone had to deal with repeated illnesses, family losses, isolation and the extreme physical difficulty of long travel. Not only did his journeys result in missionary fame but also a significant increase in European interest in Central and Southern Africa.

His speeches and writings encouraged new missions, trade routes and political interventions, so his work helped open areas such as Nyasaland, Zambia and adjoining regions to stronger British influence and later colonial control.



Fig. 2.6 (a): David Livingstone, doctor, missionary and explorer

Approximate route of David Livingstone's southern and central African journeys, 1841–1873.

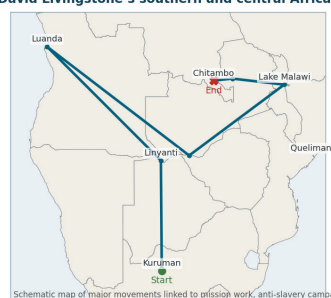


Fig. 2.6 (b): Approximate route of David Livingstone's southern and central African journeys, 1841–1873.

Samuel Ajayi Crowther

Samuel Ajayi Crowther (1809–1891), a Yoruba scholar and clergyman who had been liberated from slavery and educated in Sierra Leone, devoted his life to Christian mission, literacy and anti-slavery work in West Africa.

He took part in the 1841 Niger expedition, helped establish missions in Abeokuta and along the Niger between 1840s and 1850s, and later became the first African Anglican bishop in 1864. Crowther translated the Bible and the Book of Common Prayer into Yoruba and produced important language materials, which made Christianity more accessible to local communities. He finally faced prejudice from some European missionaries who doubted African leadership.

The result of his work was the growth of Christian education, literacy and church networks in Yorubaland and the Niger region, but those same networks also deepened British influence. In that sense, Crowther's career shows how missionary activity could both empower Africans and at the same time enlarge the cultural influence of colonial power.



Fig. 2.7 (a): Bishop Samuel Ajayi Crowther in clerical dress.

Approximate route of Samuel Ajayi Crowther's mission field in Sierra Leone and the Niger region, c. 1841-1891.

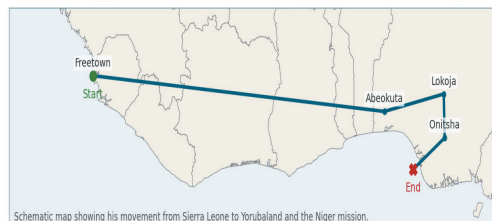


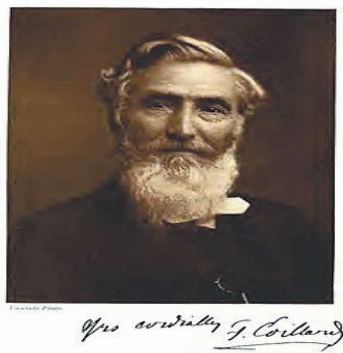
Fig. 2.7 (b): Approximate route of Samuel Ajayi Crowther's mission field in Sierra Leone and the Niger region, c. 1841-1891.

François Coillard

François Coillard (1834–1904), a French Protestant missionary of the Paris Evangelical Missionary Society, initially served in Basutoland before advancing north toward the Lozi kingdom because he wanted to evangelize, establish mission stations and spread Christian schooling.

After earlier movement in southern Africa, he was allowed by Lewanika in 1886 to found a mission in Bulozhi, and he later established important stations at Sesheke and Sefula. Coillard had an advantage because he already spoke Sotho, which was close to the Kololo used in Barotseland. Despite enduring malaria, political instability and a staggering death rate among his fellow missionaries, he persevered even after losing his wife in 1891 until he eventually succumbed to blackwater fever in 1904.

The result of his work was the consolidation of Paris Mission influence in Barotseland and stronger ties between Lozi politics and British power. His career therefore helped to facilitate the penetration of what later became Northern Rhodesia (today Zambia) under colonial rule.



Approximate route of François Coillard from Lesotho to Barotseland, 1858–1904.

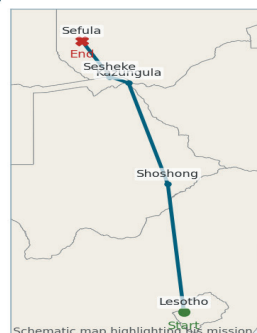


Fig. 2.8 (a): Portrait of François Coillard of the Paris Evangelical Missionary Society.

Fig. 2.8 (b): Approximate route of François Coillard from Lesotho to Barotseland, 1858–1904.

John Joseph Hirth

John Joseph Hirth (1854–1931), also known as Jean-Joseph Hirth, was a White Father missionary bishop who entered the wider Great Lakes mission field in the late nineteenth century and moved into Rwanda in 1899. His aim was to build Catholic influence by winning access to the court, converting local elites and expanding mission stations.

Between 1900 and 1901, he secured permission to establish some of the earliest Catholic missions in Rwanda, notably at Save, Zaza and Nyundo, and he later widened the church network across Rwanda and Burundi. Hirth worked in an environment already affected by German occupation and had to move carefully through court politics, social tensions and the practical difficulties of travel.

The result of his mission was the long-term expansion of Catholic education and religion in Rwanda, but it also strengthened the cultural arm of colonial rule by linking missionary institutions with the protection and authority of foreign power.



Approximate route of Bishop Hirth's early mission expansion into Rwanda, 1899–1901.

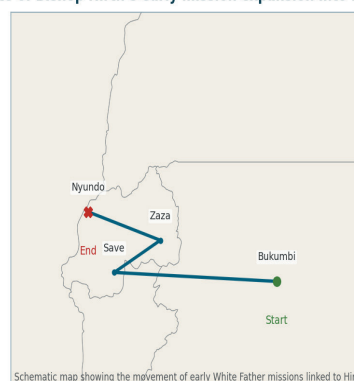


Fig. 2.9 (a): John Joseph Hirth, White Father missionary and bishop in the Great Lakes region.

Fig. 2.9 (b): Approximate route of Bishop Hirth's early mission expansion into Rwanda, 1899–1901.

2.1.3 Traders and hunters

Traders and hunters were people who entered Africa in search of valuable goods and commercial opportunities. They looked for products such as ivory, palm oil and minerals, while also searching for markets for European goods and possible transport routes.

Their activities included buying and selling goods, introducing imported products, making commercial agreements, and sometimes supplying firearms. Hunters focused especially on obtaining animal products such as ivory, while traders concentrated more on exchange and profit-making through commerce.

Frederick Selous

Frederick Courteney Selous (1851–1917), a British hunter, explorer and naturalist, entered southern Africa in 1871–1872 mainly in search of ivory, hunting grounds and adventure, though his travels soon acquired wider commercial and political significance.

Over the following two decades he moved through Matabeleland, the Zambezi region and Mashonaland, built and used routes such as the Hunter's Road, named places, wrote travel accounts and gathered detailed knowledge of local geography. In 1889 he also obtained a mineral concession for Cecil Rhodes from Mapondera and then helped guide the Pioneer Column that opened Mashonaland to company rule.

Selous experienced long travel, danger from wildlife, dependence on African rulers for permission and the decline of big game in areas of heavy hunting and the result of his journeys was to make the region far better known to Europeans, and that knowledge directly aided the advance of British influence in what became Southern Rhodesia (today Zimbabwe).



Fig. 2.10 (a): Frederick Selous with hunting gear in southern Africa.

Approximate route of Frederick Selous in Matabeleland, Mashonaland and Barotseland, 1872–1890.

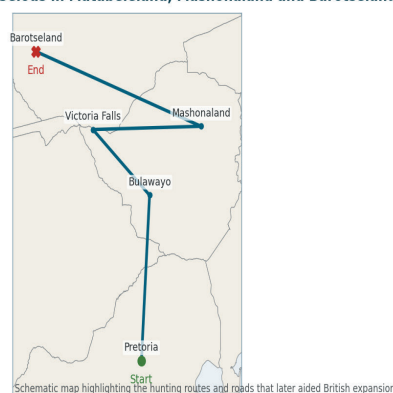


Fig. 2.10 (b): Approximate route of Frederick Selous in Matabeleland, Mashonaland and Barotseland, 1872–1890.

George Taubman Goldie

George Taubman Goldie (1846–1925), a Manx trader and colonial entrepreneur, who turned commercial competition on the Niger into a major instrument of British expansion in West Africa.

From the late 1870s he worked to merge rival British firms, and between 1882–1886 he helped to create the United Africa Company and then the Royal Niger Company, which received its charter in 1886.

Goldie's motive was to exclude French and German rivals, dominate trade in the Niger basin and convert commercial advantage into political control through treaties and monopoly.

He supported the conclusion of numerous treaties with local rulers, organized company stations and secured a British sphere that later passed to the Crown when the charter ended in 1900, and the result was decisive: the Niger basin became the core of British colonial Nigeria, showing how a trader could become a builder of empire.



Fig. 2.11 (a): Sir George Goldie, organizer of the Royal Niger Company.

Main Niger trade corridor associated with George Taubman Goldie and the Royal Niger Company, 1877–1900.



Fig. 2.11 (b): Main Niger trade corridor associated with George Taubman Goldie and the Royal Niger Company, 1877–1900.

2.1.4 Chartered company promoters

A chartered company was a business organization or company that was given special rights and authority by his home government to rule the area where it was operating.

Some colonial agents were not only individuals but also companies or the men who promoted them. They obtained charters, concessions and treaties, then used commercial privileges to establish armed and administrative control over African territories.

Cecil Rhodes

Cecil Rhodes (1853–1902), a British mining magnate and politician in southern Africa, who came to prominence through diamond wealth before turning aggressively toward territorial expansion. In 1889 he secured the charter of the **British South Africa Company (BSACo)**, which was meant to extend British rule through concessions, trade and occupation in areas such as Mashonaland, Matabeleland, Bechuanaland

and Barotseland.

Rhodes' central motive was to combine mineral wealth, imperial prestige and a broad British sphere of influence stretching northward from South Africa. Through company agents, treaties and armed columns, the BSAC moved into the interior between the late 1880s and 1890s.

The result of his work was the creation of formal British control over large parts of what became Southern and Northern Rhodesia. Rhodes therefore exemplifies how company promotion could convert private capital into territorial colonization.



Fig. 2.12 (a): Cecil Rhodes, promoter of the British South Africa Company.

Main zone of expansion associated with Cecil Rhodes and the BSAC, c. 1888-1900.

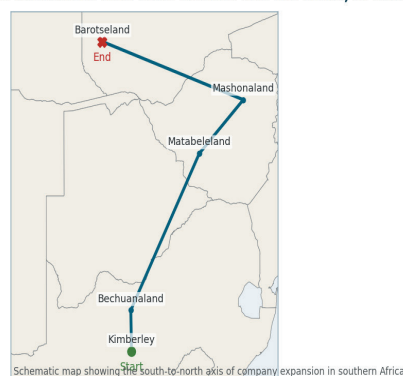


Fig. 2.12 (b): Main zone of expansion associated with Cecil Rhodes and the BSAC, c. 1888-1900.

Carl Peters

Carl Peters (1856–1918), a German nationalist, explorer and colonial promoter, entered East Africa in 1884 because he wanted Germany to secure territory quickly before rival imperial powers did so.

In 1884 he helped to create the **German East Africa Company (GEACO)**, and by 1885–1886, he and his associates had concluded a series of treaties with chiefs in Usagara, Ukami, Uzungu and nearby areas of present-day Tanzania. These agreements, however unequal, were used to justify German claims and helped secure official recognition of a German sphere in East Africa.

Peters' methods were aggressive and later became notorious for brutality and the Germany East African Company faced the Abushiri revolt in 1888–1889, which exposed the weakness of chartered company rule. Even so, the result of his activity was clear: Tanganyika was drawn into German colonial occupation, and Peters' treaty-making directly aided the partition of East Africa.



Fig. 2.13 (a): Dr. Carl Peters, founder of the German East Africa Company.

Approximate treaty-making route associated with Carl Peters in East Africa, 1884–1886.



Fig. 2.13 (b): Approximate treaty-making route associated with Carl Peters in East Africa, 1884–1886.

William Mackinnon

Sir William Mackinnon (1823–1893), a Scottish ship-owner and businessman with strong Indian Ocean commercial interests, who promoted imperial expansion in East Africa because he wanted to connect coastal trade, transport and British influence with the interior.

Mackinnon helped to establish the **Imperial British East Africa Company (IBEACo)** in 1884, and the company received a charter in 1888 to operate in the territories that later became Kenya and Uganda. Through stations, caravans and political involvement, the company pushed inland from the coast toward Buganda, but it struggled with high costs and weak finances.

Even when the company faltered support from bodies such as the Church Missionary Society, it helped to keep the project alive until Britain took over Uganda in 1894 and Kenya in 1895. The result was that Mackinnon's company served as a bridge between commerce and formal colonial administration in East Africa.



Fig. 2.14(a): Sir William Mackinnon, promoter of the Imperial British East Africa Company.

Main inland route associated with William Mackinnon's IBEA Company, 1884–1895.



Fig. 2.14 (b): Main inland route associated with William Mackinnon's IBEA Company, 1884–1895.

Leopold II

Leopold II (1835–1909), king of the Belgians, never became a field explorer in Africa, yet he was one of the most powerful colonial agents because he used diplomacy, private associations and hired expeditions to create a personal empire in the Congo where he never arrived.

During the late 1870s and early 1880s, he employed the “Association Internationale du Congo” and the services of Henry Morton Stanley to build stations, negotiate treaties and claim the Congo basin. At the Berlin Conference of 1884–1885, Leopold gained international recognition for the Congo Free State, which he ruled as a personal possession.

The result of this enterprise was the rapid conversion of exploration and treaty-making into one of the most exploitative colonial regimes in Africa, marked by forced labour, violence and international scandal. His case shows how a monarch could direct colonise from Europe while using agents on the ground to seize African territory.



Fig. 2.15: Leopold II of Belgium, promoter of the Congo enterprise.

2.1.5 Colonial administrators

Colonial administrators were officials sent by European colonial powers to govern African colonies. Once, they arrived, exploration, missionaries' activity and trade had already created pathways for control. Their activities include collecting taxes from African, supervising local chiefs and traditional leaders, maintaining peace and security for colonial government, organizing forced labour and cash crop production promoting European interests and authority, controlling African political, social, and economic activities

Richard Kandt

Richard Kandt (1867–1918), a German physician and explorer who later became Resident of Rwanda, first entered the region around the turn of the twentieth century as part of wider German efforts to survey and control the north-western frontier of German East Africa.

From the late 1890s into the first decade of the 1900s, he explored Rwanda, reported on routes and resources, and eventually established Kigali as a centre of German administration. Kandt depended on African guides, court mediation and local knowledge while also representing an expanding colonial state.

The main result of his work was administrative rather than purely scientific: his surveys helped Germany to move from occasional contact to regular occupation in Rwanda. In this way, Kandt's career shows how exploration and administration blended together to consolidate colonial rule in Rwanda before the Belgian takeover during the First World War.



Fig. 2.16 (a): Richard Kandt, physician, explorer and German Resident in Rwanda.

Approximate route of Richard Kandt's movements into Rwanda and Kigali, c. 1898-1908.

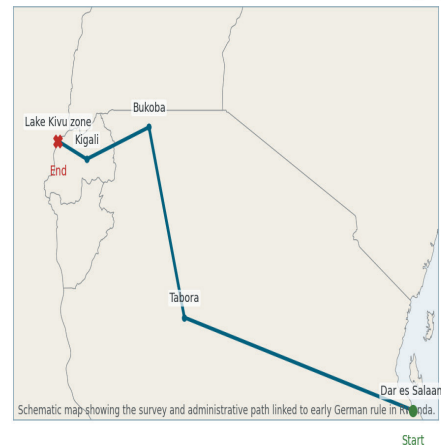


Fig. 2.16 (b): Approximate route of Richard Kandt's movements into Rwanda and Kigali, c. 1898-1908.

Frederick Lugard

Frederick Lugard (1858-1945), a British soldier and administrator, entered Africa in imperial service and worked first in East Africa before becoming one of the best-known builders of colonial government in Nigeria. In the 1890s he served the Imperial British East Africa Company and was active in Buganda, while later appointments took him to Borgu and Northern Nigeria, where from 1900 onward he helped to organise British rule and became closely associated with the policy of indirect rule.

Lugard's motive was to secure territories, establish durable administration and make empire cheaper by governing through existing authorities. He faced military resistance, long supply lines and rivalry from other powers, especially France.

The result of his career was the consolidation of British colonial administration in both East Africa and Nigeria, demonstrating how the work begun by explorers, missionaries and traders was completed by formal colonial government.



Fig. 2.17(a): Frederick Lugard in colonial field dress, later a leading British administrator.

Main African theatres of Frederick Lugard's career in East Africa and Nigeria, 1890-1906.



Fig. 2.17 (b): Main African theatres of Frederick Lugard's career in East Africa and Nigeria, 1890-1906.

Table 2.1: Summary of the main colonial agents

Agent	Main activities	Examples
Explorers	Mapping routes, describing landscapes, identifying important places, keeping journals, and writing reports about trade, culture and political organization.	Mungo Park, Speke and Grant, Henry Morton Stanley, Heinrich Barth.
Missionaries	Preaching the Christian faith, establishing churches, opening schools and health centres, translating some African languages, and teaching reading and writing. They often criticized certain African beliefs and customs as they claimed to promote Christian values	David Livingstone, Samuel Ajayi Crowther, John Joseph Hirth
Traders and hunters	Buying and selling goods, introducing imported products, making commercial agreements, and sometimes supplying firearms. Hunters focused especially on obtaining animal products such as ivory, while traders concentrated more on exchange and profit-making through commerce.	George Goldie, George Westbeech, Frederick Selous.
Chartered company promoters	They obtained charters, concessions and treaties, then used commercial privileges to establish armed and administrative control over African territories. They organized company stations, transport lines, police or armed force	Cecil Rhodes; Carl Peters; William Mackinnon; Leopold II.

Colonial administrators	Collecting taxes from African, supervising local chiefs and traditional leaders, maintaining peace and security for colonial governments, organizing forced labour and cash crop production, promoting European interests and authority, controlling African political, social, and economic activities	Richard Kandt; Frederick Lugard.
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Application activity 2.1



Instructions:

Work in groups. Read the scenario carefully and answer related questions

Scenario:

Your class is preparing a debate entitled "Before the colonial flag came." Identify one colonial agent and show how that agent entered Africa, what activities it carried out and how those activities later supported colonial rule.

Questions:

1. Present one example of the colonial agent you selected.
2. Explain how its activities influenced African political, social or economic life.
3. State one lesson African societies can learn from this history today.

2.2 Roles, problems and effects of colonial agents in Africa

Learning activity 2.2



Instructions:

Read the Rwanda-centred situation carefully. Use the lesson to explain how different colonial agents supported foreign rule.

Scenario:

In a class discussion on Rwanda around 1900, students examine the arrival of missionaries at Save, the surveys made by Richard Kandt and the spread of foreign trade. They are asked to explain how these different actions helped Germany and later Belgium to establish colonial rule.

Questions:

1. How did schools, missions and dispensaries make foreign presence easier to be accepted?
2. Why were maps, reports and resource surveys useful to a colonial government?
3. How could trade and imported goods create dependence on foreign powers?

2.2.1 Roles played by colonial agents in colonisation of Africa

Explorers

They mapped the economic potentials of Africa so that the future colonialists would know where they could establish their colonies. They discovered and drew the maps indicating the location of the strong and hostile African tribes. They show on maps where located the weak African kingdoms and befriended some Africans and their chiefs. They indicated the location of African geographical features like navigable lakes and rivers.

They called upon their home government to come and to exploit and dominate Africa, leading to the African colonization by European. They revealed to colonialists the ways of life of African people i.e. language, culture and all kind of organizations.

They took to Europe African soils sample which enabled the colonialists to identify and occupy fertile part of Africa.

They encouraged the treaty signing with some African leaders, consequently facilitated and accelerated the colonization process. They established the contacts and relationships between Africans chiefs and European colonialists. For instance, we can mention the visit of Stanley to Kabaka in Buganda and Von Goetzen to Kigeli IV Rwabugili in Rwanda. These treaties meant the surrender of African territories and sovereignty.

Missionaries

Missionaries exaggerated the wealth of Africa. For instance, Livingstone said that the minerals of South Africa were found in all areas from South Africa to Cairo. This attracted the Europeans to come and control these areas in order to exploit Africa's wealth.

Missionaries gave alarming reports about slave trade and human sacrifice which raised deep humanitarian fillings. According to them those could end if the African chiefs are overthrown and replaced by whites in colonial environment.

Missionaries played key roles in the signing treaties as long as they were working in fraternity with chartered companies and other colonial agents in luring Africans to sign treaties.

Missionaries agitated for the coming of many white settlers to come and occupy Africa. According to their plan, the white settlers would in turn seek for protection from their metropolitan countries.

Missionaries with collaboration of chartered companies trained Africans who became army men and later used by the colonialists to defeat African resistances.

Missionaries condemned African cultures and customs as backward primitive and barbaric. This weakened the African spirit of resistance and made it easy for Europeans to take over.

Missionaries built schools where they trained Africans that were to receive and work for colonialists. In such schools, missionaries trained Clerks administrators, interpreters and the masses taught the new language that imperialists would when they joined them.

Missionaries established communication facilities which were seen by European powers as favoring factors for their take over. Since they were assured of easy movements into most parts of Africa especially the interior, they did not hesitate to come to Africa to colonize it.

Missionaries did the work of softening the minds and hearts of the Africans. In their constant preaching, they emphasized on "Love one another as you love yourself". This meant that the European strangers should not be killed, but loved; which neutralized African resistance but Africans might receive European colonialists in a hospitable behavior.

Chartered companies

Chartered companies paved way for European colonization by signing treaties with African leaders. To Europeans these treaties meant surrender of the Africans thus such areas for their home government.

They exaggerated the mineral wealth of Africa, which created more appetite to colonize Africa. The British South African Company (BSACo) exaggerated the mineral wealth of South Africa; Leopold's company said that the Diamonds and copper in Congo extend up to the coast of East Africa.

Troubles of slave trade were exaggerated which forced some countries to come on a ticket of humanitarianism. These companies argued that slave trade could only be controlled if the social, economic and political lives of the Africans were firmly governed by Europeans hence leading to colonial conquests.

The Chartered companies created peace, established law and order and courts to promote justice in Africa. When all these were done, their metropolitan countries saw the situation ready for take over from the Chartered companies.

Chartered companies built social facilities like hospitals and schools that helped the colonialists to come to do their work. The fear of diseases was reduced which encouraged the imperialists to come to Africa.

Chartered companies, in collaboration with missionaries, created manpower that was to help the imperialists in colonial administration as they financed some schools that trained clerks, interpreters and administrators as colonial auxiliaries.

Chartered companies trained and equipped African Loyal Army which was used in suppressing African resistance and rebellion. It was used also in the annexation of more land for the Europeans.

Chartered companies drew the maps and boundaries of the areas under their control and their establishment meant that the partition of Africa began when the companies were still operating.

Chartered companies supported religious, internal and external wars in Africa. This was meant to weaken African military, make them become enemies to each other and force one of these seek for European protection.

Chartered companies exploited the interior of Africa, opening it to the colonialists and they drew the map of African interior locating the fishing grounds, fertile soils, forests, mineral locations, mountains and other African economic potentials. All these had to attract the colonial powers to take over Africa.

Colonial administrators

Colonial administrators were officials sent by European colonial powers to govern African colonies. They acted as agents of colonisation by helping European countries establish, organize, and maintain control over African territories by enforcing colonial laws and policies, supervising local chiefs and traditional leaders, maintaining peace and security for colonial governments, promoting European interests and authority, controlling African political, social, and economic activities

Reflective conclusion: Colonization didn't always start with a gun; it often started with a pen, a map, and a promise. Understanding this helps us be more critical and protective of our sovereignty today.

2.2.2 Problems faced by colonial agents

Colonial agents in Africa faced many serious difficulties as they moved into unfamiliar environments. One of the greatest difficulties was the prevalence of tropical diseases such as malaria, yellow fever, and sleeping sickness, which killed many Europeans before effective medicine became available.

They also travelled through harsh physical environments including dense forests, mountains, swamps, wide rivers, and vast areas without proper roads or reliable means of transport. In addition, the presence of wild animals such as lions, hyenas, leopards, and snakes threatened their lives as they moved through tropical forests.

Communication was another major problem because many explorers did not understand local languages, customs, beliefs, or political systems, forcing them to depend heavily on local guides and interpreters. However, some guides and porters were unfaithful or dishonest, sometimes stealing supplies or abandoning expeditions with luggage containing food, medicine, clothes, and water.

Explorers also faced shortages of food, clean water, medicine and manpower, especially because of the long distance between Europe and Africa, which limited support and supplies from home countries. Political insecurity and resistance from African rulers and communities further complicated their work, as many Africans opposed foreign intrusion and fought to defend their land, authority, and traditions.

Expansion wars and insecurity made it difficult for Europeans to travel freely or remain in certain regions for long periods. Missionaries also encountered the challenge of the spread of Islam, since many Africans had already embraced Islam while missionaries aimed to spread Christianity, leading to conflicts in some areas.

Furthermore, explorers often got lost because they depended on local guides or uncertain directions, and this sometimes became disastrous. Harsh climatic conditions also created difficulties, as Africa's climate was often much hotter or colder than what Europeans were accustomed to in Europe.

Due to these problems, the number of explorers, missionaries and traders was limited so that they could not effectively carry out their work in Africa. This became a great problem as long as they would operate in a large area in Africa

2.2.3 Effects of colonial agents on African societies

Effects of explorers

Explorers discovered much economic potential in Africa and this made them call upon their home government to come to occupy the regions in order to exploit which led later to colonization of the African continent. They contributed to the discovery of African rivers and lakes by Europeans like Victoria, Zambezi, Malawi, etc.

There was also evolution and spread of the Christianity religion because almost European explorers were Christians and along their paths, they had introduced their religion.

The exploration prepared the ground to the slave trade. Slaves were taken from Africa and were brought to America as the workers in different kinds of plantations and mining.

Explorers exposed the hostile tribes and the tribes who were so welcoming which facilitated the coming of the colonialists. They also encouraged the treaty signing that consequently facilitated the colonization.

Effects of the missionaries

Missionaries succeeded in spreading Christianity in Africa through evangelization, and then Africans took up new faith abandoning their traditional religion.

Missionaries campaigned against slave trade and succeeded in having it abolished in most part of Africa. They would receive and give protection to people running away from slave raiders.

They built schools where Africans received Western education and taught Africans how to write, read and to calculate. Some languages learnt were English, French, Portuguese and German. They also established health centers and hospitals which were to basically benefit the Whites and their converts and they were signs of social development in Africa.

Missionaries undermined and tried to uproot African way of life because they replaced Africans ways of life by their home civilizations and cultures. African Christian converts stopped polygamy, widow inheritance, sharing of wives, human sacrifice and killing of twins.

Missionaries contributed to the spread of European languages through education. However, there are some missionaries who studied and mastered African languages and were able to write and translate African languages. There were like Krapf who translated the New Testament of the Bible into Swahili.

Missionaries improve on agriculture by introducing new crops like coffee, cotton, sweet potatoes, palm oil trees and cacao and new methods of farming. Missionaries collaborated with traders and established the means of transport and communication lines in Africa.

Missionaries tried to bring peace and security in areas they were operating. However, in other areas they increased and planted seeds of divisionism and conflicts. They also involved themselves in the local politics.

Missionaries paved way for the colonization of Africa as they were the forerunners of the European imperialism. They signed treaties which meant the surrender of territories of the signing chiefs, they called upon their home governments to come and give them protection together with their converts.

Effects of Chartered companies

They introduced taxation system in order to enable them and their home government to operate and set up some development schemes. They rounded big spheres of influence for their home government by acquiring territories that they surrendered to their metropolitan countries. Or instance, the BSA Company annexed central and South Africa for the British and GEA Company got Tanganyika for Germany. This has reduced African resistance to colonial conquest.

They established economic assets that became the base for economic development for the imperialists. They started large plantations, industries, mining centers and farms. This was effective form of exploitation of African resources.

They prepared areas where the imperial settlers would occupy. For instance, the IBEACo reserved Kenya highlands for the British, Shire highlands of Nyasa and Shona land in Zimbabwe annexed by the BSACo.

They signed treaties with African leaders. These treaties principally meant to make these people co-operate to the white and meant that the African surrender their land.

They established the market for their home industries products. They spread European civilization and detribalized Africans, which forced them to need European goods. They even established a monetary environment which made some Africans be able to purchase European manufactured goods.

They established communication facilities like roads and railways that helped in trade, exploitation of the resources and for easing administration. They trained an African army that assisted them to carry out their duties especially annexing more territory and defeating African resistors. This army was also inherited by the imperialists who came shortly after.

They began social facilities that were a means of “modernizing and civilizing” Africa. Thus, they established schools etc which helped them in training Africans who joined their schools as they learnt how to read and write. These later became the interpreters of Europeans and administrators. They helped in the abolition of slave trade and used their armies including the local soldiers they had trained in fighting against slave trade.

Application activity 2.2



Instructions:

Work in groups. Use clear historical evidence from the unit to defend your judgement in the tribunal activity.

Scenario:

Your group is acting as a historical tribunal. One group represents explorers, another missionary, other traders or chartered companies, and another administrator. Each group must explain its role in colonization, the obstacles it faced, and the effects it left behind in Africa.

Questions:

1. Show how your assigned agent contributed to colonization using clear historical evidence.
2. Identify the main problems this agent faced and explain how it overcame them.
3. Judge whether the long-term effects of this agent were mainly harmful or beneficial to African societies. Give reasons.

2.3 The scramble and partition of Africa and their impact

Learning activity 2.3

**Instructions:**

Discuss the scenario carefully. Answer the questions using the lesson and your understanding of African sovereignty.

Scenario:

Imagine that African rulers hear that European powers are meeting in Europe to discuss African territories without African representatives. Students discuss what such a meeting would mean for sovereignty, borders and the future of the continent.

Questions:

1. What is wrong with foreign states deciding the future of African territories without Africans?
2. How can artificial boundaries create future political and social problems?
3. Why did colonial agents make the scramble for Africa easier before formal partition took place?

2.3.1 Meaning and causes of the scramble and partition of Africa

The scramble for Africa refers to the competition among European powers to acquire African territories in the late nineteenth century. It took place largely in Africa through treaties, military occupation, strategic missions and commercial expansion.

The partition of Africa refers to the formal division of African territories among European powers through diplomatic agreements in Europe, especially at the Berlin Conference

of 1884–1885. The principle of effective occupation encouraged European powers to show actual control over areas they claimed.

The scramble and partition of Africa were caused by a combination of economic, political, social, religious, and technological factors. One of the main causes was the need for raw materials such as rubber, cotton, gold, and tin to supply European industries that had expanded because of the Industrial Revolution. Europeans also wanted fertile land in Africa for the production of cash crops such as tea, coffee, cocoa, and sugar cane, whose demand was growing rapidly in Europe.

In addition, European countries searched for new markets for their manufactured goods because factories were producing more products than local consumers could buy. Wealthy industrialists also needed places to invest their surplus capital, and Africa appeared to offer profitable opportunities. Europeans further claimed that they wanted to “civilize” Africans by spreading Western education, culture, medicine, and Christianity, while also attempting to stop traditional practices and tropical diseases. Missionaries played an important role in encouraging colonization because they wanted to spread Christianity among Africans who practiced traditional religions. Population growth in Europe also increased the need for more land where Europeans could settle.

Nationalism and competition among European powers encouraged countries to acquire colonies in order to increase their prestige, strength, and influence. Colonization was also seen as a way to reduce unemployment in Europe by creating jobs in the colonies. The Franco-Prussian War of 1870–1871 contributed to the scramble because France, after losing Alsace and Lorraine to Germany, sought compensation through acquiring colonies in Africa, while Germany encouraged this policy. The mass media in Europe also promoted colonization by exaggerating Africa’s economic potential and wealth. Furthermore, the Berlin Conference of 1884–1885 accelerated the partition of Africa by establishing rules for European occupation and division of African territories. Europeans were also attracted by the availability of cheap labor in Africa, which they exploited for economic gain. Technological and medical advances brought by the Industrial Revolution, such as improved transport, communication, and the discovery of quinine to treat malaria, reduced earlier barriers to European penetration into Africa. Finally, the desire to stop the slave trade also contributed to colonization, as Europeans replaced slave trading activities with direct colonial occupation and control of African.

2.3.2 Impact of partition of Africa

The partition and colonization of Africa had major political, economic, and social effects on African societies.

Politically, African societies lost their sovereignty as European powers imposed colonial rule and removed many African leaders from power. Colonialists created larger states by combining different societies into single colonies, while artificial boundaries divided related communities and forced unrelated groups to live together, creating tensions that still influence modern African politics and regional relations. Colonial rule also encouraged divide-and-rule policies, which increased hatred and disunity among some African communities. Resistance to foreign domination led to rebellions such as the Maji Maji Rebellion in Tanzania, the MAU MAU Uprising in Kenya, and the Shona–Ndebele uprisings in Zimbabwe, causing the loss of many African lives. At

the same time, colonialism contributed to the rise of African nationalism as Africans united to fight for self-rule and independence. Colonization also connected Africa more closely to the outside world through trade and international relations.

Economically and socially, colonial economies were reorganized to export raw materials and import manufactured goods from Europe. Europeans introduced cash crops such as coffee, cotton, cocoa, rubber, and sugar cane, which promoted plantation agriculture and legitimate trade. Infrastructure such as roads, railways, and communication networks expanded mainly to support colonial administration and economic exploitation, although these later contributed to modernization and the growth of towns and urban centres.

Western education was introduced, bringing scientific knowledge and languages such as English and French, while Christianity spread widely across the continent, leading many Africans to abandon traditional religions. European cultures, including new styles of dressing, eating, marriage, and social practices, also influenced African societies, contributing to the decline of some African cultural traditions. Colonization also created long-term dependency because African economies remained underdeveloped and dependent on former colonial powers for trade, manufactured goods, and economic support (neocolonialism).

Application activity 2.3



Instructions:

Choose one case, explain it clearly, and suggest a practical response.

Scenario:

Study a map of modern Africa and select one border or region whose history was shaped by colonial partition.

Questions:

1. Describe the colonial decision that helped shape your chosen case.
2. Explain one present-day consequence of that decision.
3. Propose one practical response through regional integration, diplomacy or civic education.

2.4 End unit assessment

End unit assessment 2

Instructions:

Answer all questions clearly and support your answers with examples where necessary.

Questions:

A. Knowledge and understanding

1. Define the term colonial agents.

2. Identify four major colonial agents in Africa.
3. Explain two activities of explorers in Africa.
4. State two roles played by chartered companies in the colonization of Africa.

B. Skills

5. Show how missionaries and traders helped to pave the way for colonial rule in Africa.
6. Analyse three problems faced by colonial agents and explain how these problems affected their work.
7. Assess the main political, social and economic effects of colonial agents on African societies.

C. Attitudes and values

8. Explain the difference between the scramble and the partition of Africa, then discuss how the legacy of colonial boundaries still affects Africa today.

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UNIT 3

AFRICAN RESPONSE TO COLONIAL RULE



Fig. 3.1: illustration of African responses to colonial rule included collaboration, and resistance



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse different forms, reasons, and consequences of African responses to colonial rule in enhancing the spirit of heroism in Africa

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, learners should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Identify different forms of African responses to colonial rule
- Describe key examples of African leaders who collaborated or resisted colonial rule
- Describe the reasons why some African leaders and communities collaborated with colonial powers and the effects left on African societies
- Explain the methods used by African societies to resist colonial domination
- Explain the impacts of African resistance towards colonial rule

Skills

2

- Analyse the different forms of collaboration that helped to speed the process of colonization
- Examine the reasons for collaboration and its effects in Africa, to determine the role of the Africans in the colonization process
- Assess different methods of resistance in Africa and their cause
- Evaluate the outcomes of collaboration and resistance in shaping colonial and postcolonial Africa
- Assess the impact of historical responses on postcolonial independence movements

Attitudes and Values

3

- Value the different forms of collaboration by giving examples
- Reflect on the reasons for collaboration and its impact on African societies to appreciate them and develop the student's spirit for respect and love
- Appreciate the methods of resistance, their causes, and their effects to develop the spirit of nationalism and patriotism
- Reflect on the ethical and social implications of collaboration and resistance
- Recognize courage, leadership, and civic responsibility demonstrated by these leaders
- Develop a sense of pride, unity, and historical awareness inspired by African struggles

Introduction

This unit explains how African societies reacted when European colonial rule spread across the continent in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. African responses were not uniform. Some rulers and communities chose collaboration because they hoped to protect their people, regain lost power, defeat enemies, or benefit from new opportunities. Others resisted through war, diplomacy, strikes, boycotts, cultural defiance, and many forms of passive opposition.

The unit therefore helps students to distinguish among collaboration and resistance while also examining the reasons behind each choice. It shows that African responses were shaped by military realities, internal politics, religion, trade interests, environmental conditions, and the desire to defend dignity, land, culture, and independence.

Key words and concepts:

- Resistance
- Collaboration
- Treaty
- Colonial rule
- Nationalism
- Independence movement
- Sovereignty
- Diplomacy

Introductory activity 3



Instructions:

Study the case study below and answer the questions that follow.

Case study:

In the early period of colonial rule in Africa, foreign administrators introduced new systems of leadership, taxation, religion, and education. Some local leaders chose to cooperate because they hoped to keep their positions and secure protection. Others opposed the new order because they feared losing culture, land, and independence.

Questions:

1. What changes were introduced by colonial agents in the community?
2. Identify the forms of African responses to foreign administrators shown in the case study.
3. Why might some leaders choose cooperation instead of open resistance?
4. Why might others resist colonial rule?

3.1 Collaboration

Learning activity 3.1



Instructions:

Discuss the scenario below and answer the questions that follow.

Scenario:

You are members of the advisors at the royal court in Nyanza. A foreign colonial representative arrives carrying a treaty and supported by modern firearms. Some neighboring communities have fought and suffered greatly. Others have signed agreements and received protection, but they also lost autonomy. Discuss the questions below.

Questions:

1. Why might a kingdom facing external danger and internal rivalry consider diplomatic collaboration?
2. What short-term gains might leaders expect from signing treaties or forming alliances with Europeans?
3. What long-term costs might collaboration create for land, labour, culture, and sovereignty?

3.1.1 Meaning, forms and methods of collaboration

Collaboration was a response in which African leaders, chiefs, interpreters, soldiers and ordinary individuals worked with colonial powers instead of fighting them. Collaboration did not always mean complete surrender from the beginning. In some cases, it started as diplomacy or a temporary alliance, in other cases, it became a deeper partnership that helped colonial rulers establish administration more quickly.

Two broad categories or forms can be identified. First were legitimate rulers and chiefs (**mercenary collaborators**) who cooperated with Europeans in order to defend their states, preserve influence, or seek advantage over rivals. Second were **career or opportunistic collaborators** who were not necessarily traditional rulers but supported colonial expansion because they hoped to gain prestige, employment, protection, or wealth.

Africans collaborated in several practical ways using different methods. Some signed treaties that gave Europeans access to land, trade routes, or political authority. Some provided labour for plantations, roads, railways, military carriers, or administrative work. Others offered food, accommodation, guides, and protection to visiting colonial agents. Some African collaborators helped the whites by provided them the information about African resistances.

Mission-educated Africans often acted as interpreters or clerks. Some helped spread Christianity and Western education, which softened resistance in certain areas and created a local support base for colonial authority. In many places collaborators also collected taxes, recruited workers, enforced colonial laws, or supplied soldiers to fight resisting communities.

Table 3.1: Description of methods of collaboration

Method of collaboration	Description	Its facilitation to colonial powers
Treaties and agreements	African rulers accepted written or oral agreements with Europeans.	Political entry, claims over land, and legal justification for occupation.
Administrative support	Chiefs, interpreters, clerks, and headmen helped run local affairs.	Faster collection of taxes, labour, and information.
Material assistance	Food, shelter, guides, carriers, and military support were provided.	Safer movement and easier control of territory.
Religious and educational support	Some Africans supported mission schools and spread Christianity.	A new social base to colonial systems and values.

3.1.2. Reasons why Africans collaborated with colonial powers

One major reason was military imbalance. European armies possessed superior weapons, disciplined troops, and experience gained from earlier conquests. Many rulers concluded that immediate armed resistance would bring destruction without victory.

Some leaders collaborated because they needed protection against neighbouring enemies. Communities such as the Fante against Asante, the Maasai under Lenana against rivals, and the Baganda leadership against internal and regional enemies all viewed European support as a strategic resource. Collaboration therefore often grew out of local conflicts that existed before colonial rule itself.

Internal weakness also mattered. Societies that had been exhausted by long wars, famine, disease, cattle epidemics, or succession disputes were less able to sustain resistance. Politically segmented communities sometimes lacked a single command structure capable of organizing a united war. In such situations collaboration appeared to some leaders as the most realistic option.

Personal interest could also shape decisions. Some opportunists collaborated in order to obtain office, guns, clothing, salaries, land, prestige, or access to the new colonial economy. Mission influence also played a role in certain places by encouraging obedience to foreign authority and portraying violent resistance as undesirable. Finally, some rulers chose collaboration after seeing the defeats of neighbouring resisting communities and deciding to avoid similar suffering.

Need to protect their independence. Africans thought that through cooperation with the whites who were considered as superior, they would get protection from their enemies who were threats to their independence.

Ignorance of Africans about the intention of colonial agents. Africans didn't know that colonial agents were preparing colonization, they lived friendly with them which resulted into collaboration with colonialists.

Need of development of their kingdoms. Some kings and their subjects collaborated because they believed that fighting Europeans was against economic development (colonialists built roads, rail ways, modern houses, they brought modern clothes, medicine, etc).

Wrong impression about the whites (ignorance). In other societies collaboration was the result of ignorance, they thought that the white man was a visitor who would go back to his home any time.

Effects of slave trade. some African society collaborated because the energetic young men and women who would resist had been taken away during the period of slave trade. These societies had only children, weak, old, and sick people who could not put up any serious resistance.

Influence of missionaries. Christianity had a great influence because it preached brotherhood and oneness, thus Christians were good collaborators.

Lack of nationalism. Some societies or individuals collaborated because of the lack of love of their country; they were not interested in fighting for the independence of their kingdoms or empires.



Fig. 3.2 : Nabongo Mumia of Wanga, a leading example of political collaboration in Kenya.



Fig. 3.3: Laibon Lenana, whose alliance with the British shaped Maasai collaboration.

3.1.3 Selected cases of collaboration

The Wanga under Nabongo Mumia.

Mumia (1849 – 1949) was the king of the Wanga Kingdom in Kenya and has welcomed foreign visitors long before formal colonial rule. When British power expanded in western Kenya, he collaborated for several reasons: he wanted support against enemies such as the Luo of Ugenya and the Bukusu; he recognized the danger of British military power; and he hoped to strengthen and enlarge his influence.

His capital at Mumias became an important British centre, and Wanga fighters joined British expeditions against neighbouring communities. In return, Mumia gained status, wealth, and recognition, but British control also spread more deeply through the region.

The Maasai under Lenana in Kenya

The Maasai had once been a powerful military force, but by the late nineteenth century, they had been weakened by civil wars, cattle disease, drought, famine, and rivalry over succession. Lenana, therefore turned to the British for support against his enemies, including his rival Sendeyo and hostile neighbours. The alliance seemed useful at first, but it later exposed the Maasai to dispossession.

The Anglo-Maasai agreements of 1904 and 1911 facilitated the loss of valuable grazing land and the relocation of Maasai communities to reserves. This case shows that collaboration might produce short-term security while leading to long-term land alienation.

Buganda under Sir Apolo Kagwa.

Apolo Kagwa became one of the most important African collaborators in early colonial Uganda. He supported British influence, helped to shape the Buganda Agreement of 1900, and worked closely with the protectorate administration. Collaboration brought education, administrative reorganization, and land grants to important chiefs. At the same time, it tied Buganda more closely to British rule, changed land tenure, encouraged taxation, and strengthened social inequalities. The Baganda case is especially important because it shows how collaboration could help build a local elite inside a colonial system.

King Musinga of Rwanda

In Rwanda, king Musinga did not initially confront foreign rule. He chose to collaborate. The main reason of collaboration was the need of military support to fight rebellions against royal court. This approach helped preserve some traditional structures for a time especially under the German colonial period, but it did not prevent the later growth of colonial control under Belgium.

It is worth noting that Rwanda's collaboration with the colonial powers was influenced, in particular, by advice from the King of Karagwe to the Rwandan court.



Fig.3.4: Sir Apolo Kagwa, a central figure in Buganda collaboration.



Fig. 3.5 : Collaboration could bring short-term benefits, but it also opened the way to deeper colonial control.

Application activity 3.1



Instructions:

Read the case study and answer the questions using evidence from the unit.

Case study:

Collaboration in colonial Rwanda

Most local chiefs in Rwanda collaborated with colonial authorities and missionaries and helped them to introduce taxation, schools, mission influence, and administrative change. In return, they expected security, authority, and access to new opportunities. Yet collaboration also increased colonial power and weakened local autonomy.

Questions:

1. Identify two reasons why a local leader in Rwanda might have chosen collaboration.
2. Explain two advantages and two dangers of collaboration.

3.1.4 Consequences of collaboration

Collaboration produced mixed results. Some of its effects were immediate and visible. Collaborating rulers often received recognition, titles, gifts, salaries, weapons, or military support. Certain regions gained schools, mission stations, roads, postal services, trading opportunities, or access to the colonial administration earlier than resisting areas. For a few individuals and families, collaboration opened the way to employment, literacy, and upward mobility within the new order.

However, collaboration also accelerated colonization. By supplying food, guides, carriers, interpreters, taxes, or soldiers, collaborators helped colonial powers move, fight, and govern more effectively. These weakened resisting communities and made it easier for Europeans to establish administrative control over wider territories.

Collaboration also changed African societies internally. In some places it produced a new class of chiefs, clerks, mission-educated elites, and tax collectors whose interests became closely tied to colonial rule. This often increased inequality and created resentment among populations who felt ruled by people serving outside interests. Traditional systems of authority, landholding, justice, and religion were altered or displaced.

Other cultural consequences were serious. Collaborators often embraced Christianity, new dress styles, Western schooling, and foreign administrative models. Some Africans interpreted these changes as signs of progress, while others saw them as a loss of cultural confidence and the weakening of African religions and institutions.

Failure of African resistance. collaborators provided food, water, offered protection, military support and revealed military secrets to Europeans which led to the defeat of Africans.

Spread of European civilisation. African collaborators adopted European ways of life like dressing style, food diet, administrative and judicial system, etc to show royalty to them which led to the spread of their civilization

Table 3.2: Consequences of collaboration

Positive or short-term effects	Negative or long-term effects
Protection against enemies in some cases.	Loss of independence and deeper colonial penetration.
Access to schools, missions, trade, and administration.	Weakening of traditional authority and African culture.
Employment, titles, salaries, and prestige for some elites.	Growth of inequality and resentment inside African societies.
Relative stability in certain allied states.	Failure of resistance movements and strengthening of colonial rule.

Introduction of new infrastructure and communication.

Dependence on colonial systems and policies.

In Rwanda and elsewhere, the central lesson is that collaboration must be judged carefully. It could be a strategic choice made under pressure, but it also created openings through which colonial domination expanded. Particularly in Rwanda, the same action that seemed prudent in the short term has become harmful in the long term.

3.2 Resistance

Learning activity 3.1



Instructions:

Read the scenario and discuss the questions before studying the lesson.

Scenario:

Your community is subjected to colonial rule through heavy taxation, forced labour, foreign laws, and cultural pressure. While some members of the community advocate open armed resistance, others support strategies such as strikes, boycotts, diplomatic protest, or cultural defiance. Discuss which methods would be most effective in protecting the people and justify your answer.

Questions:

1. Categorize these methods as forms of active resistance or passive resistance.
2. Why might some communities choose concealed or non-violent forms of resistance instead of open confrontation?

3.2.1 Meaning and types of resistance

Resistance was the response of Africans who opposed the establishment or consolidation of colonial rule. Their aim was to defend political independence, territory, trade, religion, social order, and human dignity. Some communities resisted from the beginning, while others first tolerated Europeans and only rebelled later after discovering colonial intentions.

Primary resistance refers to early opposition mounted before colonial rule had become firmly established. Communities or rulers of this kind tried to keep Europeans outside their borders or to prevent occupation.

Secondary resistance refers to uprisings that occurred after some colonial presence had already been accepted but later became intolerable.

Historians also distinguish between **active resistance**, which involved open armed conflict, and **passive resistance**, which relied on refusal, strikes, boycotts, cultural survival, sabotage, or non-cooperation.

Table 3.3: Types of resistance

Type of resistance	Meaning	Example
Primary resistance	Early resistance before colonial rule became secure.	Samori Toure in West Africa; Ethiopia at Adwa.
Secondary resistance	Resistance after some colonial penetration had already begun.	Maji Maji in Tanganyika; later Nandi fighting.
Active resistance	Open fighting using armies, raids, or guerrilla tactics.	Chimurenga war; anti-French campaigns.
Passive resistance	Non-cooperation, boycotts, silence, strikes, and cultural defiance, refusal of taxes, mission schools, labour, or colonial courts.	Pogoro in present-day Tanzania

3.2.2 Methods and reasons for African resistance

Africans resisted in many ways. Armed resistance included battles, raids, and guerrilla warfare. Some communities attacked forts, military posts, missionaries, railway lines, or collaborators. Others destroyed crops planted under forced schemes, hid cattle, moved away from administrative centres, or refused to provide labour and taxes.

Passive resistance could be equally meaningful. Africans organized strikes in mines and plantations, boycotted European goods and institutions, formed independent churches, created trade unions, and later organized political parties. They wrote petitions, used diplomacy, preserved language and custom, sang defiant songs, or ignored colonial instructions. Across time, such methods fed into Pan-Africanism, liberation movements, and the demand for independence.

The reasons for resistance were equally varied.

They include the following:

Many Africans resisted colonial rule because they wanted to preserve their independence and protect their societies from foreign domination. African rulers and communities were motivated by patriotism and nationalism, seeing resistance as a way to defend their kingdoms, political authority, land, cattle, trade routes, and religious beliefs.

In many areas, colonial policies such as forced labour, taxation, land alienation, corporal punishment, and racial humiliation became unbearable and pushed Africans into rebellion. Some communities also resisted after observing collaborators being mistreated, overthrown, or dispossessed by Europeans, realizing that cooperation did not guarantee safety.

African traditional religion inspired resistance in several regions; for example, the teachings of Kinjikitile Ngwale encouraged many people in Tanganyika to join the Maji Maji Rebellion against German rule. In addition, some Muslim societies resisted because they viewed Christianity and European expansion as threats to Islam, as seen in the resistance movements of Samori Touré, the Mahdist revolt in Sudan, and the Urabist rebellion in Egypt.

Other Africans resisted because they trusted in their military and economic strength and believed they could defeat the Europeans. Leaders such as Kabalega and Samori Touré organized strong armies and hoped to defend their states successfully. Some rulers were also influenced by the collaboration of neighboring enemies; for instance, Kabalega resisted partly because Buganda had collaborated with the British, while Samori Touré opposed the French after Sikasso cooperated with them.

Resistance was further encouraged by ignorance of European military superiority, as some Africans underestimated European weapons and organization and expected victory. Others resisted because they feared losing control of profitable trade activities, especially long-distance trade and the slave trade, which Europeans sought to abolish. Long-standing hostility toward Europeans also contributed to resistance, particularly where earlier explorers, missionaries, and traders had already created tensions with African rulers. Moreover, some African societies resisted because they possessed sufficient economic resources to finance prolonged struggles against colonial occupation.

Table 3.4: Methods of resistance

Method of resistance	Purpose
Battle and guerrilla warfare	To stop occupation or make colonial control too costly.
Strikes and labour refusal	To challenge exploitation and weaken colonial production.
Boycotts	To deny profit, legitimacy, or obedience to colonial institutions.
Independent churches and associations	To defend dignity, religion, and African leadership.
Diplomatic protest and petitions	To seek justice or reform without immediate war.
Cultural defiance	To preserve identity, unity, and moral resistance.
Formation of political parties	To fight against colonial rule

3.2.3 Selected case studies of African resistance

Al-Hajj Umar Tall and French expansion in West Africa

Al-Hajj Umar Tall opposed growing French influence in the Senegal hinterland because he understood that commercial penetration would soon become political domination. Fighting began in the late 1850s after French duplicity and frontier tensions deepened.

Although Umar did not expel the French, he delayed their expansion, revealed the strength of African resistance, and forced the French to reconsider the scale of force needed for colonization.



Fig. 3.6: Louis Faidherbe, the French governor whose expansionist policy provoked resistance in Senegal.



Fig. 3.7: Al-Hajj Umar Tall, one of the major early resisters to French imperialism in West Africa.

Samori Toure and the Mandinka empire

Since the 1880s, Samori Toure (1830-1900) built a strong state in the present-day Mali and Guinea and resisted French expansion for many years. He fought to preserve independence, trade, and political authority. His resistance combined diplomacy, military reform, and strategic movement across large territories.

Samori reorganized his army, sought firearms, relocated when necessary, and used flexible tactics to avoid total destruction. In the end, he was defeated, but his long struggle became one of the clearest examples of determined African heroism against colonial conquest.



Fig. 3.8 : Samori Toure, whose prolonged resistance became a symbol of African determination.

The Maji Maji war, 1905-1907

Maji Maji broke out in German East Africa, especially in the south of Tanganyika. The immediate cause was the compulsory cotton scheme imposed by the Germans. Africans were forced to work on communal cotton plots under brutal supervision, yet they received little or no benefit.

Other grievances included harsh taxation, corporal punishment, the abuse of power by Arab akidas and askaris appointed under German rule, and the general brutality of colonial administration. The movement drew strength from the Maji belief, which convinced many people that spiritual protection would make them invulnerable.

The rebellion failed for several reasons. German troops were better armed; African fighters lacked a unified command; and the broad coalition weakened when famine, devastation, and fear increased.

Even so, Maji Maji was historically important. It caused terrible destruction and famine, but it also taught Africans the limits of poorly coordinated armed resistance. It influenced later political consciousness in Tanganyika and pushed the German government to introduce reforms under Governor Von Rechenberg.

The Shona-Ndebele (Chimurenga) war, 1896-1897

In what later became Zimbabwe, the Ndebele and then the Shona rose against the British South Africa Company. The causes included the loss of independence, land alienation, cattle seizures, forced labour, taxation, interference with trade, and deep suspicion of white intentions.

Religious belief and the Mwari cult helped mobilize people, while the Jameson Raid showed that the British were not invincible. The war was eventually defeated, but it remains a central symbol of Zimbabwean memory because it demonstrated unity against colonial domination.



Fig. 3.9: *Illustration of Chimurenga fighters resisting colonial occupation in Southern Africa.*

The Nandi resistance in Kenya (1890-1906)

The Nandi resisted British penetration for many years, making it one of the longest resistances in East Africa. The strength of the struggle came from a warrior tradition, difficult terrain that favoured guerrilla tactics, youth mobilization, and the absence of willing local collaborators.

The death of Koitalel arap Samoei weakened the resistance, but the Nandi struggle remains an important example of African military courage and persistence.



Fig. 3.10: Koitalel arap Samoei, remembered for the Nandi resistance in Kenya.

A success story: Ethiopia at Adwa

Not all African resistance ended in defeat. The Ethiopian victory at Adwa in 1896 showed that African military success was possible where leadership, weapons, strategy, and unity were strong. This victory inspired pride across Africa and the diaspora and remains one of the greatest symbols of African sovereignty.

3.2.4 Reasons of failure of most of African resistances

By 1914 apart from some pockets of resistance, most African states had been conquered by Europeans with a lot of ease. In spite of their attempts to resist, Africans were finally defeated because of the following reasons:

Military and technological superiority of Europeans: Europeans used fire arms while Africans used spears and arrows which were inefficient.

The policy of "divide and rule "which was used by Europeans against Africans: for example, in Uganda, the English formed a friendship with Buganda against Bunyoro.

The impact of Christianity: they were taught to be faithful to their masters and consequently when colonialism came to Africa, very few people stood up against it.

Africans were economically weak and as a result could not sustain long wars that required a lot of financial means.

The effects of slave trade: the young and strong who would have been good soldiers had been taken away and sold as slaves. Consequently, Africa was left with a population that could not have the bravery to fight.

Some selfish Africans betrayed their compatriots: in some countries, soldiers deserted their front lines and went to reveal secrets of wars waged by their brothers.

Diseases: the most striking example is that of syphilis among the Ndebele.

The African soldiers were not well trained: they were not able to march the war skills of colonial armies in many instances.

Civil wars led to the failure of Africans: in the sense that these wars created division among Africans which ended up weakening them.

3.2.5 Consequences of African resistance to colonial rule

African resistance had painful immediate consequences. Fighting caused death, depopulation, displacement, destruction of houses and crops, famine, disease, and social disruption. Colonial armies often used scorched-earth tactics, punitive expeditions, forced removals, and mass executions. For many communities the cost of resistance was therefore extremely high.

Yet resistance also had important long-term significance. It preserved the memory of African courage and proved that colonial domination was contested, not accepted voluntarily. The names of resisting communities and leaders later inspired nationalists thought, anti-colonial politics, and independence struggles. Even defeated revolts planted ideas of unity, dignity, and patriotic duty.

In some places resistance also forced colonial reforms. After Maji Maji, for example, the German administration recognized that brutal rule could provoke devastating rebellion. More broadly, resistance exposed the violence at the heart of colonial conquest and showed later generations why freedom mattered.

At the same time, historians must explain why many resistances failed. Colonial armies had superior weapons and logistics. African resisters were often divided, isolated, or weakened by famine and disease.

Missionaries, explorers, and collaborators sometimes provided information or support to the invaders. In addition, slave trade and earlier wars had already drained the continent of strength in many regions. Failure in battle therefore did not mean lack of bravery; it often reflected the unequal conditions under which Africans fought.

Table 3.5: Consequences of resistance

Major consequences of resistance	Historical importance
Deaths, displacement, famine, and destruction.	Showed the high human cost of colonial conquest.
Defeat of some African armies and occupation of territories.	Demonstrated the military imbalance between Africa and Europe.
Colonial reforms in some territories after major revolts.	Revealed that resistance could still force policy change.
Growth of nationalism and heroic memory.	Inspired later independence movements.

Table 3.5: Consequences of resistance**Application activity 3.2**

Instructions:

Compare the two resistance movements using evidence from the unit.

Task:

Compare two resistance movements of your choice, for example Samori Toure and Maji Maji, or Maji Maji and Chimurenga.

Questions:

1. State the major causes of each resistance movement.
2. Identify the methods used in each case.
3. Explain why one movement may have lasted longer or achieved more than the other.

Table 3.6: Comparative review of major case studies

The table below helps you compare the major collaboration and resistance cases studied in this unit.

Case	Region	Type of response	Main causes	Main consequences
Wanga under Mumia	Western Kenya	Collaboration	Need for security, British military power, wish to expand influence, existing hospitality to foreigners.	Rise of Mumia's prestige, British expansion in western Kenya, resentment among neighbouring communities.

Maasai under Lenana	Kenya	Collaboration	Civil war, famine, cattle disease, need for British help against rivals.	Short-term alliance but long-term land loss and relocation to reserves.
Buganda under Apolo Kagwa	Uganda	Collaboration	Political survival, alliance with British, administrative opportunity.	Land changes, taxation, strengthening of a colonial elite, deeper British control.
Al-Hajj Umar Tall	Senegal / Western Sudan	Resistance	Desire to stop French expansion into the interior.	Delayed French conquest and showed the seriousness of African resistance.
Samori Toure	Mandinka empire / West Africa	Resistance	Defense of independence, trade, and political authority.	Long resistance, heroic memory, eventual French victory.
Maji Maji	Tanganyika	Resistance	Forced cotton growing, harsh rule, taxation, brutality.	Mass death and famine, but later reforms and nationalist memory.
Chimurenga	Zimbabwe	Resistance	Loss of land, cattle, trade, freedom, and respect.	Suppressed uprising, but enduring symbol of anti-colonial unity.

3.3 End unit assessment

Summative assessment 3

Instructions:

Answer all questions clearly. Use simple and correct examples where needed.

A. Knowledge and understanding

Identify two forms of African responses to colonial rule

Define the following terms: collaboration and resistance

State four reasons why some African leaders collaborated with colonial powers.

Identify four methods used by Africans to collaborate with colonial rulers

Point out two examples of resistance and mention four methods used by Africans to resist colonial rulers.

B. Skills

6. Explain how collaboration helped colonial rule to spread faster in Africa.

7. Compare collaboration and resistance as two African responses to colonial rule.

C. Attitude and values question:

8. What lesson can African students gain from the courage shown by resistance leaders?

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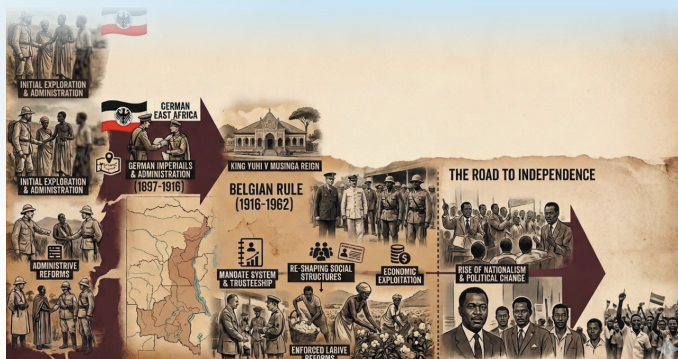
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UNIT 4

RWANDA UNDER GERMAN AND BELGIAN COLONIAL RULE (1897-1962)



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse the impact of colonial rule on Rwanda's political, social and economic structure and its legacy in shaping modern Rwanda identity and governance.

Fig. 4.1: illustration of Rwanda under German and Belgian rule

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, learners should be able to:

1 Knowledge and understanding

- Explain the main causes of German and Belgian colonization of Rwanda.
- Describe the German administration and its impact.
- Describe the reforms introduced under Belgian administration.
- Describe the effects of Belgian colonization of Rwanda during Belgian military occupation, mandate and trusteeship.
- Explain the causes and consequences of the 1959 crisis in Rwanda.
- Describe the process of independence of Rwanda.

2 Skills

- Analyse the causes of German and Belgian colonization and the lessons that can be learnt from them.
- Examine the impact of German colonization of Rwanda on political, economic and social domains.
- Assess the political, economic, judicial, socio-cultural reforms introduced by Belgians to determine their influence.
- Examine the effects of Belgian colonization on Rwanda.
- Analyse the causes and outcomes of the 1959 crisis to understand its historical significance.
- Evaluate the process of independence of Rwanda

Attitudes and Values

3

- Judge the causes of German and Belgian colonization of Rwanda.
- Acknowledge the impact of German colonization of Rwanda on Rwandan society.
- Recognize different reforms introduced by Belgians in Rwanda.
- Show concern for the effects of Belgian colonization of Rwanda during military occupation, mandate and trusteeship.
- Acknowledge the causes and consequences of the 1959 crisis in Rwanda.
- Appreciate the efforts of Rwandans who contributed to the struggle for independence.

Introduction

This unit examines the period between 1897 and 1962, when Rwanda moved from an independent kingdom to a territory controlled first by Germany and then by Belgium. It helps students understand how colonial rule changed leadership, land use, labor relations, religion, education, taxation, trade, and the meaning of identity in Rwanda. The unit also shows that colonial rule was not a simple one-way process. Rwandans collaborated, resisted and sometimes suffered severe disruption. By studying these developments, students can explain both immediate colonial changes and their long-term legacy in modern Rwanda.

Key words and concepts

- Exploration
- Protectorate
- Indirect rule
- Mandate / Trusteeship
- Identity cards - Ibuku (1935)
- Decolonization
- Independence

Introductory activity 4



Instructions:

1. Read the scenario and discuss the questions before the lesson begins.
2. Give short answers based on your prior knowledge and listen respectfully to others.

Scenario:

A community in Rwanda experiences two colonial changes within one generation. German officials first arrive and choose to work through the king and chiefs. Some years later, Belgian authorities intervene more directly: they impose taxes, demand labour, promote compulsory crops, support mission schools, conduct censuses, and issue identity cards that classify people in fixed categories.

Some people cooperate in order to protect their positions, others resist openly, and still others avoid direct confrontation while trying to preserve family life and local customs.

Questions:

1. Which changes in the scenario show the difference between German rule and Belgian rule?
2. How could force labor and identity cards affect daily life and relations among neighbors?
3. Why might some Rwandans choose cooperation while others choose resistance or indifference?
4. What lessons can Rwanda learn today from studying this colonial experience?

4.1 Rwanda under the German colonial rule (1897-1916)

Learning activity 4.1

**Instructions:**

1. Read the situation carefully.
2. Identify what it suggests about colonial motives, local institutions, and indirect rule.
3. Answer in simple and clear sentences before reading the lesson.

Situation:

A small group of German officials reaches a kingdom that already has a king, chiefs, military organization, and systems of order and tribute. Because the officials are few and still learning about the country, they do not immediately replace the existing structure. Instead, they rely on the Mwami and selected chiefs while gradually gathering information and extending influence.

Questions:

1. Why would this kind of policy be useful to the Germans in Rwanda?
2. What does the situation show about the strength of precolonial Rwandan institutions?

3. What advantages could the Germans gain by ruling through local leaders?
4. What risks could this system create for Rwanda's independence and internal authority?

4.1.1 European exploration and early contacts with Rwanda

Before formal colonization, Rwanda was little known to most Europeans and was often described as a remote or mysterious kingdom [located in Moon Mountains / "*Les montagnes de la Lune*"]. Explorers, geographers, missionaries, and imperial agents became interested in the region because of the search for the source of the Nile, the desire for trade routes, and the growth of European imperial ambition in East and Central Africa.

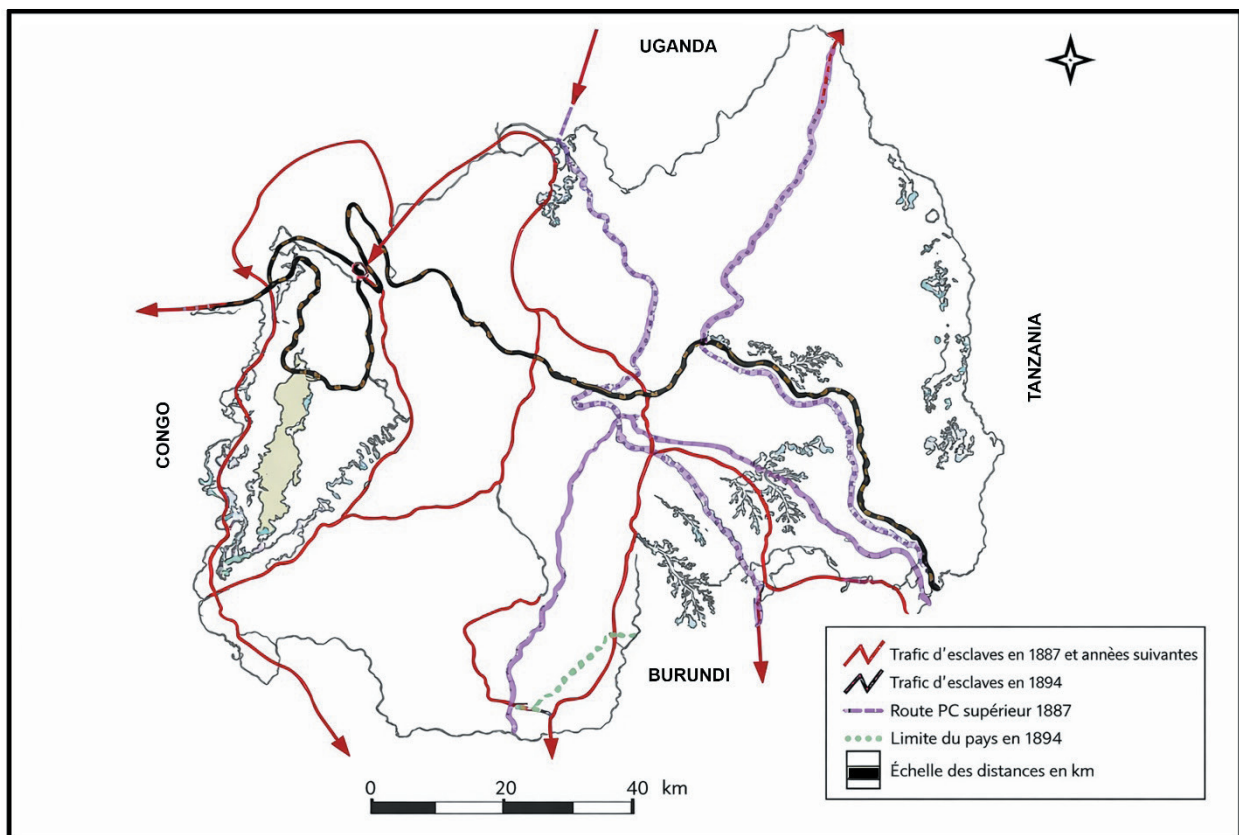


Fig. 4.2: Routes of the first European explorers interested in Rwanda.

Table 4.1 European explorers and early contacts with Rwanda

Explorer(s)	Date	Main purpose	Outcome for Rwanda
Richard Francis Burton, John Hanning Speke and James Augustus Grant	1856-1861	The first group of explorers interested in Rwanda while searching for the source of the River Nile	They were unsuccessful in penetrating into Rwanda. They reached Lake Victoria and Tanganyika but reported from nearby Karagwe and spread stories about the kingdom originating from myth about the inhabitants of Rwanda, according to which Rwanda was a dangerous and mysterious country where foreigners were not welcome.
Henry Morton Stanley	1876	Exploration and regional information gathering	He reached Lake Ihema, failed to enter the interior because he was drawn back by the local population. He wrote that Rwanda could be entered only with caution.
Dr. Oscar Baumann	1892	Search for the source of the Nile and anti-slavery mission	The first European to penetrate into Rwanda. He passed through southern Rwanda (Gisagara District) and helped increase German geographical interest.
Count Gustav Adolf von Götzen	1894	Exploration and political contact	He became the first European to cross Rwanda and established the first official colonial contact with the court of King Rwabugiri. He was impressed by the personality of the king.
Dr. Richard Kandt	1898-1907	Geographical research and later administration	He explored the country, studied the river system, and later became the first German Resident in Rwanda.

These explorations did not immediately amount to full control, but they prepared the way for imperial claims. They provided geographical information, encouraged missionary interest, and introduced Rwanda to competing colonial powers.

4.1.2 Causes of German and Belgian colonisation of Rwanda

German and Belgian interest in Rwanda formed part of the wider scramble for Africa. European powers did not come for one single reason. They were driven by a combination of economic, political, strategic, religious, and ideological motives.

Table 4.1 Main causes of German and Belgian colonization of Rwanda

Cause	Explanation
Need of raw materials and natural resources	Germans and Belgians sought raw materials and believed African territories, including Rwanda, could support extraction and supply wider imperial economies.
Need of land for cash-crop production	They wanted fertile land for cash crops such as coffee, tea and other to develop their industries
Need of cheap labour	They needed a work force to cultivate in their plantations
Need of markets for manufactured goods	They looked for external markets in which to sell manufactured products.
Investment of surplus capital	Colonial territories were seen as areas in which European capital could be invested for profit.
Strategic and political prestige	Possessing colonies increased international status and strengthened imperial competition among European states.
Population pressure and unemployment in Europe	They claimed that overseas territories could offer room for settlement and new employment opportunities.
Spread of Christianity and Western civilization	They justified expansion in religious and civilizing Africans in terms of language, reading and writing among others
The Berlin Conference of 1884-1885	The Berlin framework encouraged European powers to formalize claims in Africa and provided diplomatic support for territorial occupation.

4.1.3 The German administration in Rwanda

German occupation and stages of administration

The first important political contact came in 1894, when Count Gustav Adolf von Götzen met King Kigeri IV Rwabugiri at Kageyo in Kingogo (currently in Ngororero district). Later, under Yuhi V Musinga, German missions were pushed further toward formal political control.

On 20 March 1897, Captain Ramsay arrived at Runda under the reign of King Yuhi V Musinga. Captain Ramsay was the regional military chief of Tanganyika – Kivu whose capital at Ujiji (in Tanzania). On this occasion, King Musinga's court was deeply wary of the Europeans and was highly suspicious of European intentions. To safeguard the young King Musinga from potential danger, assassination or capture, the court devised a deception strategy. The royal court choose Mpamarugamba to meet Captain Ramsay in place of the monarchy because he bore a striking facial and physical resemblance to King Musinga. He was dressed as a king and sent to meet the German expeditionary force. Through this deceptive meeting,

Mpamarugamba accepted the German flag and a formal letter of protection. This act officially formalized the German protectorate over Rwanda.

On 5th March 1898, the King MUSINGA and Bethe concluded a pact that placed Rwanda under German protectorate.

In the early phase, Rwanda was administered within the wider structure of German East Africa. At first, German control was mainly military and depended heavily on local authorities. After 1907, civilian administration was established when Dr. Richard Kandt was appointed Resident and Kigali was developed as an imperial residence.

Table 4.2 Main phases of German administration in Rwanda

Phase	Period	Main features
Military phase	1897-1907	German officers supervised occupation through military posts at places such as Gisenyi and Shangi. They relied on the king and chiefs to maintain order and to transmit colonial demands. Rwanda and Burundi together were ruled by Captain Bethe with the imperial residence at Usumbura (present day Bujumbura)
Civil administration phase	1907-1916	Administration was transferred to Kigali under Richard Kandt as Resident. Census conduct, taxation, policing, and tighter supervision increased, although indirect rule remained the basic method.

Collaboration of the royal court (king)with the Germans

The Germans could not govern Rwanda effectively without cooperation from the royal court and leading chiefs. Musinga accepted collaboration especially in order to defeat the rebellions who opposed his authority after the Rucunshu war.

Rwandan oral traditions and later written accounts also suggest other reasons such as reports from neighbouring kingdoms suggested that Europeans possessed strong weapons and military strength such as the advice from the king Rumanyika of Karagwe to the Rwandan court; the wish to protect Musinga's position; the hope of learning more about the foreigners before resisting; the influence of missionaries , gifts and benefits from Germans; disunity of Rwandana due to Rucunshu war, and fear of losing political power if resistance failed.

Resistance to German colonial rule

Collaboration did not mean complete acceptance. The German administration supported Musinga against opponents in different regions, especially in the north. Resistance emerged where rebellions opposed both German interference and central royal control.

Among the best-known resistors were Ndungutse, Rukara, Basebya, and Muserekande alias Nyiragahumuza. Their actions took different forms, ranging from armed revolt to guerrilla warfare (with the use of traditional weapons) and spiritual mobilization. During resistance, Ndungutse claimed royal legitimacy and drew support from areas

such as Buberuka, Kibali, Bukonya, and Murera. Rukara, a former warrior commander, became famous for resisting foreign interference and for the killing of Father Paulin Loupias in the context of local conflict. Basebya also led guerrilla operations in northern Rwanda and Nyiragahumuza used the Nyabingi cult as a means of mobilization and denounced colonial teaching that treated indigenous religion as satanic.

The rebellions were later suppressed with German force, and their defeat strengthened both German influence and royal central authority. Ntungutse's

fate, unlike Rukara and Basebya who were killed in 1912, remains a mystery. Some say he died on the battlefield, while others say he went into exile.

Border changes and the Brussels Conference of 1910

Another major event during German rule was the redrawing of Rwanda's borders. In 1910, Belgium, Germany, and Britain met in Brussels and fixed borders between Rwanda, Belgian Congo, Uganda without consulting local populations. Rwanda lost extensive territories, including Ijwi, Bwishya, Gishari, and Bufumbira. This decision disrupted older political and social organization and reduced the size of the kingdom.



Fig. 4.3: Rwanda before the delimitation of 1910.



Fig. 4.4: Rwanda after the delimitation of 1910.

Coming of missionaries and Islam

Missionary activity expanded during German rule. White Fathers of the Roman Catholic Church arrived in 1900 and established missions at Save, Zaza, Nyundo, Rwaza, Mibilizi, Kabgayi, Rulindo, Murunda, Kansi, and Kigali respectively. They pursued evangelization, education, health care, and charitable work, but they also helped spread European values and strengthened foreign influence.

German Protestant missionaries of the Bethel Society arrived in 1907 and founded mission stations at places such as Kilinda in 1907, Rubengera in 1909 and Remera-Rukoma in 1912

Islam also became more firmly rooted during this period through Swahili-Arab traders, soldiers, interpreters, and clerks linked to German networks. Muslim communities established trade centers and, by 1913, built the first mosque in Kigali known as Al-Fatah.

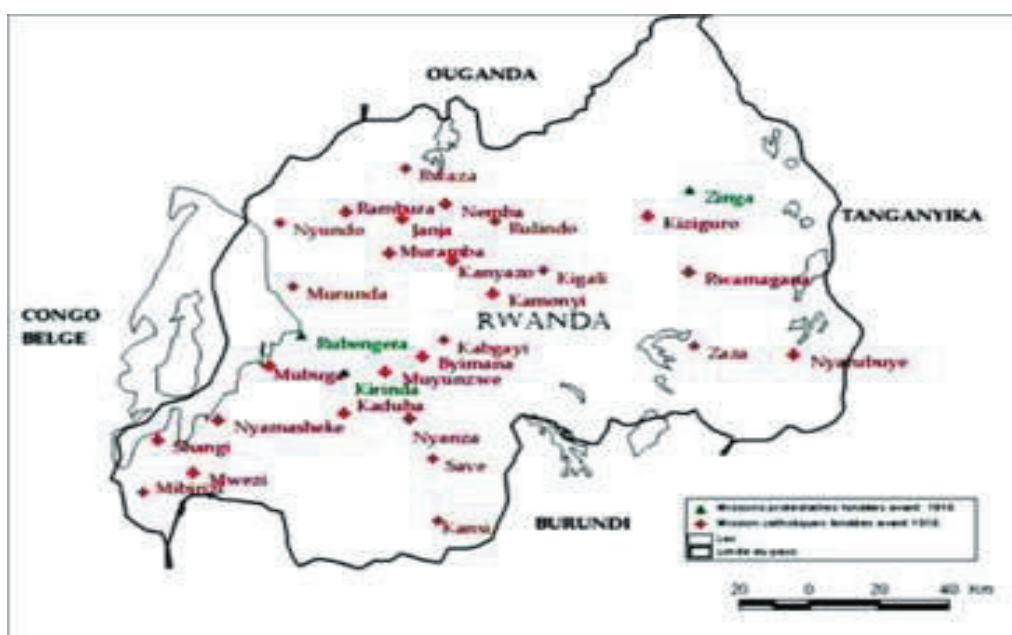


Fig. 4.5: Early Catholic mission stations in Rwanda.

World War I and the end of German administration

World War I transformed the colonial situation. Although central Africa had earlier been associated with neutrality agreements, fighting spread into the region after 1914. German troops in East Africa tried to maintain their positions, while Belgium and Britain coordinated operations against them.

In Rwanda, the royal court supported Germany with armed companies "*Indugaruga*" and food supplies, partly in the hope of recovering lost territories such as Ijwi. Belgian forces advanced from the Congo and Uganda sides, occupied Kigali on 6 May 1916 and Nyanza on 19 May 1916, and continued operations in other regions. Belgian victory in 1916 ended German rule in Rwanda.

The war brought destruction, crop loss, and famine under the name of *Rumanura* or *Rumanurimbaba*.

4.1.4 Impact of German colonisation on Rwanda

German rule was relatively short compared to Belgian rule, but it left important marks on Rwanda.

Politically, the Germans maintained indirect rule and relied on the Mwami and chiefs, yet they also strengthened outside influence over internal affairs. They helped Musinga suppress rebellions and opened the kingdom to increased foreign intervention.

Economically, the Germans introduced taxation in money (head-tax), encouraged exports such as hides and skins, arrival of Arab and Indian merchants, expanded trade contacts, and began modest infrastructure and crop projects. Some eucalyptus trees were planted along the roads and a few coffee trees were planted. They also encouraged the use of coins such as the rupee and heller, which helped move parts of the economy away from barter trade.

Socially and culturally, the period was marked by the arrival and expansion of Catholic and Protestant missionaries, limited formal schools, and the growth of Islam through trade.

The era prepared the way for more intrusive Belgian reforms. In this sense, German rule served as a bridge between an independent kingdom and a more direct colonial state.

Table 4.3 Impact of German colonization on Rwanda

Domain	Positive impact	Negative impact
Political	Use of existing institutions reduced immediate disruption and preserved some local forms of authority and rebellions were repressed	Real decision-making increasingly shifted toward the colonial power; and border changes were imposed from outside.
Economic	Introduction of money, head-taxes, expansion of trade, and new commercial contacts widened economic exchange...../	Taxation, labor demands, and export priorities served colonial interests more than local needs.
Social and cultural	Mission schools and medical work introduced some new services.	Foreign religions and institutions weakened older practices and prepared the way for deeper colonial interference.

Application activity 4.1



Instructions:

1. Use the lesson to answer the questions clearly.
2. Prepare a short class presentation based on your answers.

Task context:

Prepare a simple museum panel on German colonial rule in Rwanda. The panel must explain why Germany came, how it ruled, how Rwandans responded, and what effects this period left behind.

Questions:

1. State two causes of German colonization of Rwanda.
2. Identify one example of collaboration and one example of resistance during German rule.
3. Explain two political, economic, or social effects of German rule in Rwanda.
4. In two or three sentences, state one lesson modern citizens can learn from this period.

4.2 Rwanda under Belgian colonial rule (1916-1962)

Learning activity 4.2



Instructions:

1. Read the prompt carefully.
2. Sort the changes into political, economic, and socio-cultural categories.
3. Predict possible effects before reading the lesson.

Prompt:

A colonial administration says it is modernizing Rwanda. It reorganizes chiefdoms, changes who can become a chief, promotes mission schools, imposes taxes and compulsory crops, demands labour, and later records people in fixed identity categories.

Questions:

1. Which of these changes are political, economic, and socio-cultural?
2. Which reforms might appear useful at first sight, and why?
3. Which reforms could create inequality, resentment, or division?
4. Why is it important to study both reforms and their long-term effects?

4.2.1 Belgian military occupation (1916-1924) and its reforms

After defeating Germany in Rwanda in 1916, Belgium did not wait for final peace agreements before exercising authority. Belgian occupation troops replaced German forces, and Rwanda was reorganized under military rule. Administrative divisions were created mainly to simplify military orders, food requisition, and the recruitment of carriers.

By 1917 Rwanda had been divided into military territories (Gisenyi, Ruhengeri, Cyangugu and Nyanza), and later into four principal territories, that's Western territory with Rubengera as capital city, Northern territory with Ruhengeri as capital city, Nyanza with Nyanza as capital city, and Eastern territory with Kigali as capital city.

Major De Clerck became Resident in 1917, and in 1919 a civilian resident, F. Van Den Eende, replaced him. In 1920 George Morteau took office and since then, the logic of military occupation continued until the mid-1920s.

Table 4.4 Main reforms during Belgian military occupation

Reform	Explanation
Ban on the king's legal right over life and death (1917)	The king lost the unconditional right to decide over the life and death over his subjects and remained increasingly with a symbolic or honorary role.

Limitation of the king's political power to appoint and dismiss chiefs (1923)	The monarchy could no longer freely choose or remove chiefs without approval from the Belgian representatives.
Freedom of religion under colonial supervision (1917)	The king was obliged to accept religious freedom, which weakened his politico-religious authority and gave wider space to missionary expansion
Fiscal reforms of 1924	Traditional practices such as Imponoke and Indabukirano were abolished or altered as Belgium expanded its own tax and administrative systems. Imponoke consisted of cows given as gifts to a chief who had lost cows in huge numbers while Indabukirano consisted of cows that were given to a new chief upon assuming his duties as a new leader in a given area.
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The Gisaka affair and the Orts-Milner Convention

Before the Treaty of Versailles was finalized, Belgium negotiated with Britain over parts of former German East Africa. Through the Orts-Milner Convention of 30 May 1919, Belgium agreed to transfer Gisaka and other areas from Rwanda and Burundi to Britain in exchange for British support on another territorial question linked to the mouth of the Congo River. When British plans changed, the agreement was reversed. The League of Nations approved the return of the annexed Rwandan territory in 1923, and Britain evacuated it at the end of that year. The episode shows how colonial powers treated African territories as bargaining objects, often with little regard for the people who lived there.

4.2.2 Reforms under the Belgian Mandate (1924-1946)

After First World War, an international peace keeping body was formed under the name of League of Nations. The conquered territories were placed under the supervision of the League of Nations, and the administration of the mandates was delegated to certain victorious powers until the areas could govern themselves. The mandates were divided into three classes (A, B and C) respectively based on their level of development at that time and on how they could govern themselves.

Rwanda was classified under Mandate B providing that the mandatory country (Belgium) in theory, was expected to administer the territory while promoting the welfare of the population and preparing conditions for future self-government. But in practice, Belgium annexed Rwanda administratively to the Belgian-Congo and simply applied on it the Congolese colonial law.

Political and administrative reforms

The most famous political reforms of the Mandate period were the Morthan reforms beginning in 1926. They reorganized Rwanda into territories, chiefdoms (chefferies), and sub-chiefdoms (sous-chefferies) and abolished the older functions of land chiefs, cattle chiefs, and military chiefs. The new system centralized authority while aligning it more closely with colonial control.

This restructuring changed the social meaning of power. Sons of chiefs educated in colonial schools were preferred because the Belgians regarded them as modern and loyal auxiliaries.

Another decisive event of this period was the deposition of King Yuhi V Musinga in 1931. Belgian officials and Catholic missionaries accused him of resisting colonial and missionary programmes. He was removed, deported to Kamembe (today in Rusizi District), and later exiled to Moba in the Belgian Congo. Mutara III Rudahigwa, his son, was then raised on the throne. Musinga's removal shows how colonial rule could use local institutions while still overturning them.

Economic reforms

Agriculture became the central field of colonial intervention. Food production programmes were officially justified as measures against famine, but the administration also imposed compulsory cultivation known as **Ishiku**. Families were required to grow particular crops and sometimes to work far from home in order to satisfy colonial inspections and transport routes.

Cash-crop farming, especially coffee, became increasingly compulsory. By the early 1930s peasants and chiefs alike were assigned minimum numbers of coffee trees to plant. Coffee exports rose sharply, but this did not mean equal prosperity for the population. Much of the burden fell on rural labourers who supplied land, time, and unpaid or poorly paid work. In addition, Belgian rule also promoted livestock rearing especially cattle. Selection farms such as Songa, animal health services and veterinary centres were established in rural areas.

Fiscal changes were made and since 1917, taxes were paid in cash by all Rwandan adults to add on to the colonial funds. The mining activities were also introduced and were mainly carried out by MINETAIN company, SOMUKI, and GEORWANDA. They were also the development of transport and communications networks brought about the introduction of bicycles and cars from Europe and Asia as from 1927. Moreover, this network joined trading centres that started forming important urban centres such as Kiramuruzi, Kigali, Nyanza, Astrida, Kamembe, Gisenyi and Ruhengeri. Fishery, forestry, and environmental control programmes were introduced as well.

Furthermore, Belgians introduced forced labour "**Akazi**" that required people to work on plantations, roads, churches, schools, hospitals, and anti-erosion trenches. Because the labour was usually unpaid or underpaid, many Rwandans fled to Uganda, Tanganyika, and the Congo in search of freer and better paid work.

Socio-cultural reforms

Belgian rule also reshaped culture and social institutions. The abolition of *Ubwiru* and *Umuganura* in 1925 weakened two major pillars of the monarchy. Formal mission schooling increasingly replaced *Itorero* as a route to recognition and leadership. Education, however, remained strongly controlled by Christian missions and was not distributed equally across the population.

Health programmes expanded through hospitals, dispensaries, vaccination campaigns, and training for medical assistants. While these brought some medical services, they were also linked to colonial interests in creating a healthy labour force.

Religion changed deeply as well. Catholic influence became stronger, and in 1946, Mutara III Rudahigwa consecrated Rwanda to Christ the King. Traditional practices such as "*kubandwa*" and "*guterekera*" were prohibited under the new political-religious order.

One of the most consequential reforms was the introduction of identity cards in 1930. These cards, known as "*ibuku*", recorded information such as clan, marital status, parents, residence, and the ethnic category Hutu, Tutsi, or Twa. What had earlier been more flexible social identities became increasingly fixed "ethnic groups" in official administration.

4.2.3 Reforms under the Belgian Trusteeship (1946-1962)

After World War II, the United Nations replaced the League of Nations and introduced the Trusteeship system. Rwanda entered this framework through an accord concluded in December 1946 and approved by the Belgian Parliament in 1949. In principle, the new arrangement required Belgium to lead Rwanda gradually toward self-rule and independence.

The United Nations Trusteeship Council monitored this process through missions and reports. Belgian reforms during this period therefore responded not only to local conditions but also to international pressure.

Political reforms under Trusteeship

The most important political reform was the establishment of consultative councils by the decree of 14 July 1952. These included the high council of the state, territorial councils, chiefdom councils, and sub-chiefdom councils. That new structure opened limited channels of participation as the real power remained strongly shaped by colonial supervision. Another political reform in 1949 created a Government Council for Ruanda-Urundi. It mostly served colonial administration, since its composition favoured officials and foreigners rather than broad Rwandan representation.

This period was also marked by:

- Formation of political parties in 1959 such as UNAR (Union Nationale Rwandaise), RADER (Rassemblement Democratique du Rwanda), PARMEHUTU (Parti du Mouvement pour l'Emancipation Hutu) and APROSOMA (Association pour la Promotion Sociale de la Masse) in the process of independence;
- 1959 crisis, and the sudden death of the King Mutara III Rudahigwa on 25th July 1959.

Economic and social reforms under Trusteeship

Belgium launched the Ten-Year Economic and Social Development Plan in 1951 after criticism from the first UN mission of 1948. The plan expanded roads, marshland drainage, tree planting, schools, hospitals, and dispensaries, while also deepening cash-crop production and labour mobilisation.

On his initiative, Mutara III Rudahigwa abolished *ubuhake* based on cattle in 1954, an important measure that reduced one form of clientship and released many pastoral clients. Land reforms, however, continued to operate within a colonial framework that emphasized productivity and state supervision.

The period also consolidated Christianity, especially the Catholic Church, in public life, while forcing further decline of older practices. Although these reforms could appear modernizing, they often produced uneven benefits and left unresolved tensions around power, education, and identity.

4.2.4 Effects of Belgian colonisation on Rwanda

Table 4.5 Effects of Belgian colonisation on Rwanda

Domain	Key changes	Overall effect
Political	Restructuring of chiefdoms; abolition of older chiefly functions; stronger colonial control; deposition of king Musinga; formation of consultative councils.	The monarchy was weakened and traditional authority was reshaped to serve colonial goals. New institutions introduced limited participation but not full self-rule.

Economic	Cash crops, especially coffee; forced labour; compulsory cultivation; taxes in cash; mining; roads and trading centres.	Colonial rule expanded production and infrastructure, but the gains were unequal and often depended on coercion.
Social	Mission schools, hospitals, dispensaries, Christian expansion, migration for labour, new urban centres. Identity cards, ethnic groups classifications, suppression or weakening of certain traditional institutions and practices.	Some services expanded, yet education and opportunity remained unequal and many people experienced hardship, forced movement, and exclusion. Divisions that later fed political violence.

Application activity 4.2



Instructions:

1. Use examples from the lesson in each answer.
2. Keep your answers brief, clear, and focused on evidence.

Task context:

A youth club asks to explain how Belgian colonial reforms shaped leadership, labour, identity, and social relations in Rwanda, and what lessons this history offers for unity and citizenship today.

Questions:

1. Explain two reforms introduced during Belgian rule and what each changed.
2. Describe two harmful effects of Belgian reforms on leadership or social relations.
3. State one reform that seemed modernizing and explain why its benefits were limited.
4. Give two lessons young people can apply today to promote equality and national unity.

4.3 Rwanda from 1959 up to 1962

Learning activity 4.3



Instructions:

1. Read the situation carefully.
2. Identify the factors that could produce political crisis.
3. Predict the main problems before reading the lesson.

Situation:

Rwanda is moving toward self-rule, but tension is growing. The monarchy wants faster autonomy, Belgium delays decolonization, political parties begin to compete, identity politics hardens, and the sudden death of Mutara III Rudahigwa shocks the country.

Questions:

1. Which factors in the situation could lead to a political crisis?
2. How could the death of a widely respected king increase instability?
3. Why must the 1959 crisis be studied together with colonial rule and decolonization?
4. What warning signs of future violence appear in this situation?

4.3.1 The 1959 crisis in Rwanda

The 1959 crisis grew out of tensions that had developed over several years. From the mid-1950s, the royal court and sections of the Rwandan elite criticised Belgian reluctance to grant self-rule, the Catholic Church's dominance in education, and the unfairly limited role of Rwandans in political administration.

In 1954, Mutara III Rudahigwa abolished *ubuhake* without colonial approval. In 1957 the high council of the state prepared the ***Mise au point*** memorandum, which criticised Belgian policy and demanded faster progress toward autonomy.

The Belgian response helped to polarize politics further. Colonial officials encouraged or supported the publication of the ***Hutu Manifesto*** in 1957, which framed power in "ethnic" terms and accused the monarchy and the Tutsi elite of domination. Tension sharpened again after the sudden death of Rudahigwa on 25 July 1959.

When violence broke out in November 1959, it was often described by its supporters as a social revolution. Yet recent historical documentation shows that anti-Tutsi violence, arson, displacement, and political targeting were central features of the crisis. The violence spread from Gitarama (Muhanga District) to almost throughout the country. Colonel Guy Logiest was brought from the Congo, and Tutsi chiefs and sub-chiefs associated with the old order were dismissed, arrested, exiled, or replaced.



Fig. 4.6: King Mutara III Rudahigwa. Photo: Charles Dessart (date?), Ruanda-Urundi, Bruxelles. P73.

Causes of the 1959 crisis

- Belgian divide-and-rule policies that transformed traditional social classes into "ethnic" groups to confirm that there was nothing common between the Hutu, the Tutsi and the Twa.
- Discriminatory distribution of power and opportunity in colonial administration and education;
- Growing conflict between Mutara III Rudahigwa and the Belgian administration, especially over education, representation, and the pace of self-rule;
- The sudden death of Rudahigwa, which removed a powerful symbol of unity and of the independence struggle;
- The wider climate of the Cold War in which superpowers wanted to gain political and economic influence (capitalism and communism) throughout the world. Belgians accused the monarchy of preparing independence in form of the communist system. They conspired against the Tutsi elite to support Hutu leaders.

Consequences of the 1959 crisis

- Loss of life many Tutsi were killed, destruction of their homes, livestock, crops, and businesses;
- Exile of the Tutsi to neighboring countries such as Uganda, Tanzania, Burundi, Congo, Kenya, throughout the world.
- Arbitrary arrests of Tutsi, imprisonments, dismissals, and political intimidation;
- Replacement of many chiefs and sub-chiefs Tutsi by members aligned with PARMEHUTU under the supervision of Guy Logiest;
- Entrenchment of "ethnic" ideology, discrimination, and regionalised power, which later contributed to the path that culminated in the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi.

4.3.2 The process of independence in Rwanda

Rwanda was a UN Trust Territory; therefore, the process of independence was closely observed by the UN Trusteeship Council. Between 1948 and 1960, UN missions repeatedly criticised Belgium for delaying decolonisation. At the same time, political competition inside Rwanda intensified.

Table 4.6 Main stages in the process of independence in Rwanda

Date	Event
1948-1960	Five UN Trusteeship council missions (each 3 years) visited Rwanda and criticised Belgium for delaying independence.
1952	Belgium introduced representative organs through statutory reforms.
1956	Amendments expanded universal suffrage at the level of the councils.
February 1957	The Mise au point memorandum demanded stronger Rwandan representation in administration.
March 1957	The Hutu Manifesto which framed power in "ethnic" terms
1958	A committee created by Rudahigwa analysed the so-called Hutu-Tutsi social question and concluded that the problem was political rather than "ethnic".
May-Sept. 1959	Political parties such as UNAR, APROSOMA, PARMEHUTU, and RADER became central actors in public life.
June-July 1960	Communal elections were held; PARMEHUTU was declared the winner. This occurred because many members of UNAR, the majority of whom were Tutsi, were killed during the events of 1959, while others who escaped persecution sought refuge in neighboring countries and elsewhere around the world.
26 October 1960	A provisional government was created under Resident Jean-Paul Harroy, with Gregoire Kayibanda as prime minister.

28 January 1961	Proclamation of Republic at Gitarama (Muhanga District) with Dominique Mbonyumutwa appointed as president.
25 Sept. 1961	Legislative elections were held
26 Oct. 1961	Gregoire Kayibanda was elected president of the First Republic.
1 July 1962	Rwanda became independent.



Fig. 4.7: *Dominique Mbonyumutwa, appointed first president of Rwanda.*



Fig. 4.8: *Gregoire Kayibanda, elected first president of Rwanda.*

Role of the United Nations Trusteeship Council

The United Nations Trusteeship Council was responsible for supervising Belgium's administration of Rwanda under the Trusteeship system created after the Second World War. Its task was to make sure that the territory moved gradually toward self-rule and independence. To do this, it relied on annual reports and on visiting missions sent in 1948, 1951, 1954, 1957, and 1960.

These missions examined political representation, labour, education, economic policy, and social conditions, and they repeatedly criticized Belgium for delaying decolonization and for maintaining discriminatory and anti-democratic practices in Rwanda.

The Council also influenced the final phase of decolonization. International pressure helped to push Belgium toward reforms such as the consultative councils of 1952 and later electoral changes that modestly widened participation. The United Nations followed the crisis of the late 1950s, observed the 1961 referendum and elections, and

later fixed the final road to independence, which came on 1ST July 1962.

However, the Trusteeship system had clear limits: it failed to prevent the anti-Tutsi violence of 1959 and after, and Belgium continued to shape the transition in ways that favored the new regime. The role of the Trusteeship Council was therefore important, but incomplete.

Table 4.7. Summary of chronology of major events in Rwanda from precolonial Rwanda to colonial rule and finally to independence

Date	Event
1894	Count Gustav Adolf von Götzen crossed Rwanda from east to west and meets King Rwabugiri.
1896	Rucunshu conflict brought Yuhi V Musinga to power.
1897	German protectorate begun to take shape in Rwanda.
1898	Bethe concluded the pact placing Rwanda under German protection.
1900	Save mission is founded; Catholic missionary activity expanded
1907	Creation of Kigali imperial Residence under Richard Kandt.
1910	Brussels Conference redrew Rwanda's borders.
1914-1918	World War I affects East Africa and leads to the fall of German rule in Rwanda.
1916	Belgian occupation of Rwanda begins.
1924	Belgian Mandate over Rwanda is approved.
1926	Georges Morteau reforms begin restructuring administration by replacing the traditional system with Territories, Chiefdoms, and Sub-chiefdoms, while abolishing the powers of traditional chiefs and system with a colonial structure.
1931	King Yuhi V Musinga is deposed; Mutara III Rudahigwa became king.
1935	Identity cards (Ibuku) are introduced. The Belgian administration introduced identity cards that classified every Rwandan as Hutu, Tutsi, or Twa, transforming these previously flexible social categories into fixed "ethnic" identities.
1946	Rwanda placed in the UN Trusteeship system.
1952	Consultative councils are introduced.
1954	Mutara III Rudahigwa abolishes ubuhake based on cattle.
1957	Mise au point memorandum and Hutu Manifesto deepen political tension.
1959	Death of Mutara III Rudahigwa; 1959 anti-Tutsi violence erupted in November.
1960	Communal elections are held; PARMEHUTU is declared the winner.

1961	The Republic was proclaimed at Gitarama (Muhanga District)
1 July 1962	Rwanda became independent.

Application activity 4.3



Instructions:

1. Use information from sections 4.3.1 to 4.3.3.
2. Answer the questions, then prepare a short oral report.

Task context:

A civics club asks to explain how Rwanda moved from crisis and Trusteeship to independence, and what should have been protected during that transition.

Questions:

1. State two roles played by the United Nations Trusteeship Council in Rwanda.
2. Identify two major events that marked the road to independence between 1959 and 1962.
3. Explain one limitation or failure of the Trusteeship system in Rwanda.
4. Suggest two principles that should guide a fair transition to independence in any country.

4.4 End unit assessment

Summative assessment 4

Instructions:

1. Answer all questions clearly in full sentences.
2. Use examples from the unit wherever possible.
3. Where required, give your own reasoned opinion.

A: Knowledge and understanding

1. Explain four main causes of German and Belgian colonization of Rwanda.
2. Describe two features of German administration in Rwanda.
3. Identify three reforms introduced during Belgian rule in Rwanda.
4. Explain two causes and two consequences of the 1959 crisis in Rwanda.

B: Skills

6. Compare German indirect rule with Belgian rule in Rwanda. What were the main similarities and differences?
7. Analyse how Belgian reforms changed political authority, labor, and social relations in Rwanda.

C: Attitudes and values

8. In your opinion, which colonial power had the deeper long-term impact on Rwanda? Justify your answer.

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UNIT 5

DIVISIVE COLONIAL POLICY IN RWANDA



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse European ethnicism and the role played by colonization in dividing Rwandans

Fig. 5.1: illustration of colonial rule transforming flexible social identities into rigid ethnic categories and linked public power to ethnic labeling.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, learners should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Describe European theories on Rwandan immigration and settlement
- Explain linguistic theories and anthropological interpretations
- Describe the role of colonial power and catholic clergy in promoting ethnicity in Rwandan society
- Describe the consequences of "ethnic" practices in Rwanda

Skills

2

- Analyse European theories on Rwandan immigration and settlement
- Examine linguistic theories and anthropological interpretations
- Analyse the role played by colonial power and catholic clergy in promoting "ethnicity" in Rwandan society
- Evaluate the consequences of "ethnic" practices in Rwanda

Attitudes and Values

3

- Judge European theories on Rwandan immigration and settlement
- Appreciate linguistic theories and anthropological interpretations
- Recognize the role played by colonial power and catholic clergy in promoting "ethnicity" in Rwandan society
- Acknowledge the consequences of "ethnic" practices in Rwanda

Introduction

This unit examines how colonial rule transformed flexible, historically shaped social categories into rigid "ethnic" labels. It shows how explorers, missionaries, and colonial administrators applied false ethnic theories and used administration, education, religion, and official documents to spread and institutionalize those ideas. The unit also explains how the Belgian Mandate and later Trusteeship deepened divisions through indirect rule, administrative reforms, political favoritism, and the use of ethnic identity in public life. Finally, it traces how these divisions contributed to the ethnic awakening of the late 1950s and early 1960s, reshaping leadership, access to education, social relations, and political competition.

Key words

- Hamitic hypothesis
- Bantu expansion
- "Ethnic" ideology
- Indirect rule
- "Ethnic" identity cards
- Trusteeship
- Ethnic awakening
- Unity
- Reconciliation.

Introductory activity 5



Instructions:

Read carefully to the scenario and answer the questions.

Scenario:

In a certain school, all students speak the same language and study together. However, a new school rule begins to classify them into separate groups based on family background.

One group is said to be more intelligent and suitable for leadership, while another is described as suitable mainly for manual work. Over time, opportunities are no longer shared fairly. Suspicion grows, friendships weaken, and some students start believing that these labels are natural and permanent. A teacher then asks the class whether these differences were always so important, who created them, and how the school can rebuild unity.

Questions

1. What problem do you observe in the school described in the scenario?
2. Do you think the divisions in the scenario are natural or created? Give reasons.
3. How can labels and stereotypes affect relationships among people?
4. Why is it dangerous when unequal treatment is justified as something normal?

5.1 European theories on Rwandan immigration and settlement

Learning activity 5.1



Scenario:

A teacher writes two statements on the board: "Some Rwandans came from outside Africa and were naturally born to rule." "The history of Rwanda should be explained through evidence such as language, archaeology, oral traditions, and long interaction among people."

The class is asked to decide immediately which statement is correct, but to think about what questions each statement raises and what kind of evidence would be needed to test it.

Questions:

1. Which idea in the first statement immediately makes you curious or doubtful? Explain.
2. What kinds of evidence would you expect historians to use when studying the peopling of Rwanda?
3. Why is it risky to accept a theory that describes one group as naturally superior before examining evidence?

European explorers, missionaries, and colonial agents wrongly described Rwandans as separate "ethnic" groups. Instead of seeing Rwanda as a society shaped by a shared language, long interaction, and changing social relations, they interpreted its history through the racial ideas that were common in Europe at the end of the nineteenth century. In that framework, Hutu, Tutsi, and Twa, which were social categories, were presented as peoples of different origins, unequal capacities, and unequal historical roles.

These writers reduced the history of Rwanda to waves of migration. According to this view, the Twa were treated as indigenous inhabitants, the Hutu as later agricultural settlers, and the Tutsi as foreign pastoral conquerors who allegedly came with superior intelligence and political ability.

This theory was speculative, selective, and deeply biased. It ignored the complexity of settlement, the continuity of human occupation, intermarriage, social mobility, and the fact that power and identity in precolonial Rwanda were not fixed in the ethnic way later claimed by colonial authors.

Actually, Hutu, Tutsi, and Twa existed in precolonial Rwanda mainly as social categories rather than fixed ethnic groups. Individuals could move between categories over time, and members of each group were found in different social positions, including both wealthy and poor households."

5.1.1 Linguistic theories

Linguistic theories tried to explain the settlement of Rwanda by tracing the spread of language. Early European linguists proposed the idea of a Prototype-Bantu language and linked agriculture, cattle keeping, and metal work to the spread of Bantu speakers. However, many of them combined language with "ethnicism" thinking. They argued that the so-called Hamites had introduced civilization into sub-Saharan Africa and had influenced or led to Bantu expansion.

Such interpretations gave linguistic evidence a meaning it could not legitimately carry. Language does not automatically prove "ethnic" group, social value, or superiority. By focusing too narrowly on migration, these theories underestimated the long human presence in the Great Lakes region and the contribution of groups that may have spoken other languages before Bantu languages became dominant. They also failed to explain the many cultural adaptations that took place within Rwanda over time.

Table 5.1 Major stages in the evolution of these theories

Stage	Period	Main claim	Critical comment
1	1863-1924	African origins were linked to Asia; Hamites and Bantu were treated as late migratory waves. Explorers such as Speke and Von Götzen influenced this thinking.	"Ethnicity", language, and civilization were wrongly mixed together.
2	1920s-1945	Outside migration theories were questioned after new fossil discoveries, but the Hamitic hypothesis remained influential in schools and administration.	Colonial power continued to use the theory to justify exclusion.

3	1949-1954 onward	The Hamitic myth was challenged and gradually dismantled; Bantu expansion became the dominant explanation.	Physical appearance could not scientifically identify a so-called Hamite.
4	Late twentieth century	Greenberg and other linguists placed early Bantu origins in the Nigeria-Cameroon borderlands and traced later expansion toward the Great Lakes.	Even here, dates, routes, and causes of migration remained open to debate.

5.1.2 Anthropological interpretations

Anthropological interpretations also tried to classify African populations into separate physical groups such as Negroid, Europoid, Khoisanoid, and Pygmy. In this approach, Eastern Africa was imagined as a meeting place of population groups. The spread of Bantu languages was then treated as evidence for the arrival of Negroid populations, while material culture and physical traits were linked to other supposed races.

This approach was also limited. Archaeology in Rwanda and the wider Great Lakes region has remained incomplete, and no serious interpretation can rely on physical type alone. Human settlement must be studied through several kinds of evidence: archaeological remains, environment, oral traditions, language, and changing social practices. Simplified oppositions such as 'Tutsi cattle keepers' against 'Hutu agriculturalists' are misleading because farming and cattle keeping often complemented each other and varied from one region to another.

For these reasons, the chronology of settlement in Rwanda cannot be reduced to a neat "ethnic" sequence. Much of the older narrative was shaped less by science than by colonial ideology. Students should therefore approach all early "ethnic" explanations critically and recognize that the origins and interactions of Rwanda's population were more complex than these theories claimed.

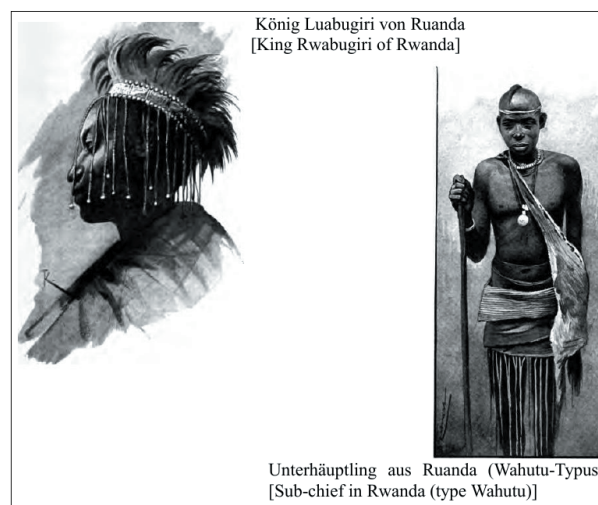


Fig. 5.2: Engravings of King Rwabugiri and a Hutu sub-chief reproduced from Gustav Adolf von Götzen's travel account. The image reminds students that political authority in precolonial Rwanda cannot be reduced to a simple "ethnic" scheme.

Application activity 5.1



Instructions:

1. Use the lesson to explain the old theories briefly, evaluate them critically, and avoid language that may spread stereotypes.
2. Present your answers in clear sentences and end with a message that promotes critical thinking and unity.

Task context: The Community Radio Program

A local radio station invites Senior Four students to present a short program on the peopling of Rwanda. The students realize that if they repeat colonial theories without analysis, they may misinform the audience and strengthen harmful stereotypes. They therefore decide to explain the theories, identify their weaknesses, and present a balanced message that promotes critical thinking and unity.

Questions:

1. What main points should your radio message include when presenting the old European theories on the peopling of Rwanda?
2. How would you show the audience that these theories had important weaknesses and biases?
3. What final message would you give so that listeners value evidence, reject stereotypes, and protect unity?

5.2 Role of colonial power and catholic clergy in promoting “ethnicity” in Rwandan society

Learning activity 5.2



Instructions:

1. Before reading the section, identify what has changed in the way people are being described and treated.
2. Predict which institutions or documents may be responsible for that change.
3. Share your ideas and questions with the class.

Scenario:

In a community, people have long lived together, shared the same language, and worked with one another. Later, new administrators arrive and begin recording people under fixed “ethnic” labels.

School places, leadership roles, and official papers start to depend more and more on those labels. Religious teachers and local authorities also begin repeating the idea that these differences are natural. Students are asked to think about how such changes could happen and who might help to spread them.

Questions:

1. What signs in the scenario show that flexible social categories are becoming fixed identities?
2. Which institutions or actors seem likely to spread and strengthen those labels?
3. What questions does this situation raise about power, education, religion, and official documents?

Before colonial rule hardened identities, Hutu, Tutsi, and Twa were part of one wider Rwandan society shaped by a shared language, culture, kingdom, and many local variations. Colonial rule changed the meaning of these categories. Through administration, schooling, missionary writing, and political practice, social distinctions were turned into fixed ethnic labels and linked to hierarchy.

5.2.1 Definition of the native policy by Belgian Mandate (1926–1948)

After the First World War, Belgium replaced Germany in Rwanda. The new authorities knew little about local realities and relied heavily on missionaries, especially the White Fathers, to interpret the country for them. The writings of Father Léon Classe became especially influential. He presented Rwanda as a feudal society ruled naturally by a Tutsi aristocracy. This interpretation simplified many regional variations and gave colonial power a ready-made political model.

Belgium chose indirect rule but heavily modified and manipulated it for colonial control. In theory, Europeans would govern through existing institutions while acting as guides and educators. In practice, however, indirect rule meant selecting some local actors as preferred intermediaries. The Tutsi aristocracy was chosen for this role on explicitly “ethnic” grounds. Colonial and missionary writers described Tutsi as intelligent, refined, and born to rule, while Hutu were portrayed as hardworking but politically limited, and Twa were placed at the bottom of a colonial social order.

Table 5.2. Colonial measures that weakened the monarchy and subordinated it to Belgian rule

Year	Measure	Effect on the monarchy and society
1917	Suppression of the king's unconditional right over life and death	A core symbol of sovereignty was transferred to Belgian authority.
1917	Declaration of freedom of worship	The monopoly of traditional religion was broken, to the advantage of Catholic missions.

1922	Resident's delegate assisted the king in judicial matters	Royal justice was brought under colonial supervision.
1923	The king could no longer appoint or dismiss chiefs freely	Chiefs became responsible first to colonial administrators, not to the King.
1925	<i>Ubwiru</i> and <i>Umuganura</i> were abolished; leading ritual authorities were removed	Key cultural and ideological foundations of the monarchy were weakened.
1931	Deposition of Yuhi V Musinga and Enthronement of Mutara III Rudahigwa	The monarchy survived, but now as an institution more directly shaped by colonial goals. The source of authority was in the hands of colonialists

The weakening of the monarchy was therefore not a single event but a long process. Colonial officials restricted royal justice, ritual authority, appointments, and control over the countryside. By the time Musinga was deposed in 1931, the monarchy had already lost much of its earlier autonomy. The enthronement of Rudahigwa kept the institution alive, but under much tighter colonial direction.

5.2.2 Administrative reorganization and power monopoly of Tutsi

Administrative reform further deepened divisionism. The Belgian authorities simplified Rwanda's structure by abolishing the traditional system of "*igikingi*", three chiefs and replacing it with a hierarchy that they considered easier to control. The Resident acquired decisive power in appointments and dismissals, while the king was left mainly with ceremonial approval.

The 1926 Mortehehan reform and related changes also reworked local territorial divisions. Ibikingi divisions were abolished, many lower authorities were removed, and chieftaincies were regrouped. By the end of 1933 there were 65 chiefs and 1,043 sub-chiefs; later regroupings reduced the numbers to 56 chiefs and 860 sub-chiefs in 1938, 51 chiefs and 625 sub-chiefs in 1947, and 55 chiefs and 559 sub-chiefs in 1959.

This was presented as administrative efficiency, and it had a strong political effect: Schools that trained future chiefs and administrators also favored those already close to the colonial system. Children from Tutsi chiefly families were more likely to access such schools, while Hutu were increasingly excluded from authority.

During the 1929 reform, for example, no Hutu chiefs were retained. This did not mean that every Tutsi benefited equally or that every Hutu was poor; rather, it shows that colonial administration made ethnicity a stronger factor in access to power than before.

5.2.3 Catholic clergy and the spread of ethnic ideology

Catholic clergy did not all act in the same way, but missionary institutions played a major role in spreading ethnic ideology. Mission stations were not only religious centers; they were also places where social knowledge about Rwanda was produced and circulated. Missionary schools, journals, and reports repeated the notion that Tutsi were naturally suited for command. In this way, "ethnic" stereotypes entered classrooms, administrative thinking, and political language.

One of the principal defenders of the Tutsi cause was Mgr Classe. On one hand, he pursued the missionary strategy mentioned above, which consisted of converting the ruling class to Christianity. On the other hand, he wanted to implement the Tutsi-Hamitic theory. Mgr. Classe exaggerated the praises of the innate qualities of the Tutsi and their exceptional intellectual capacities compared to Hutu

Later, as decolonization approached, important sections of the Church shifted their support toward Hutu emancipation. This did not mean abandoning ethnic thinking. Rather, the same colonial framework was often reused in a reversed form: instead of supporting a Tutsi elite as "natural rulers", some clergy now supported Hutu political mobilization as the correction of an old injustice. Because the debate remained trapped in "ethnic" categories, it deepened polarization instead of creating a shared national solution.

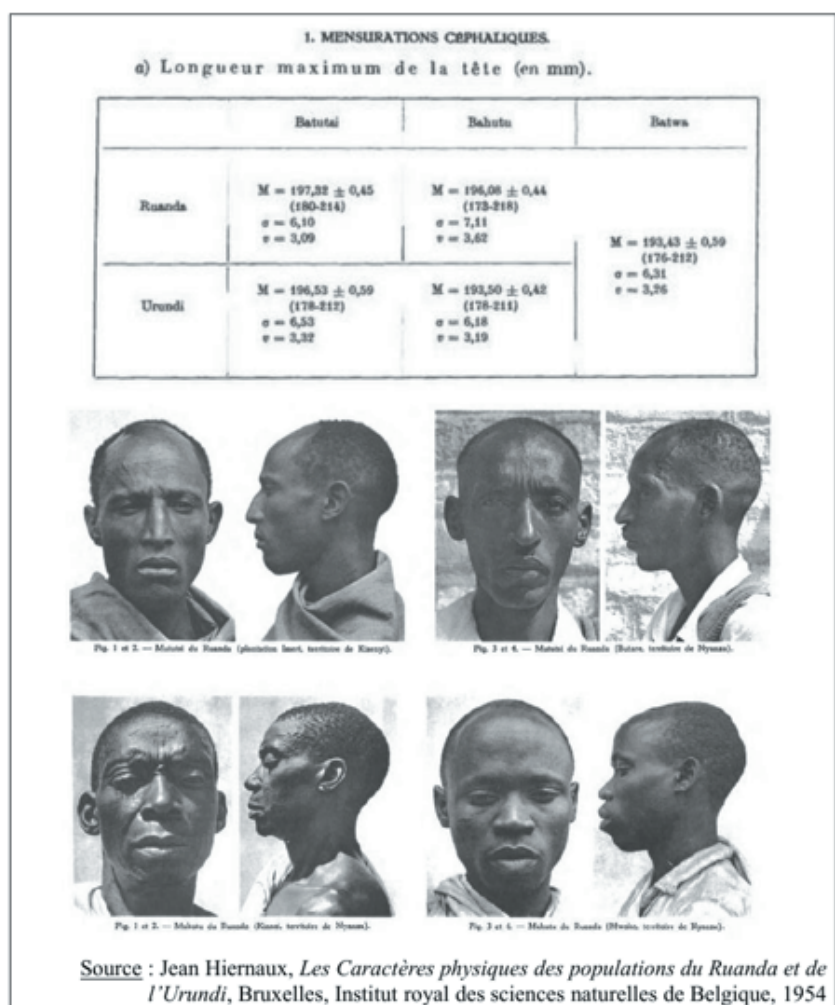


Fig. 5.3: The physical characteristics of the population of Rwanda-Urundi, 1954

5.2.4 Identity cards and the institutionalization of ethnicity

One of the clearest ways in which colonial rule fixed ethnicity was through official documents. In the 1930s, Belgian-issued identity booklets included a field for tribe, later changed to “ethnic” groups after the Second World War. Individuals were classified as Hutu, Tutsi, or Twa. This practice survived independence and influenced access to public employment, education, and political opportunity.

Once identity became an official administrative category, it became easier for the state and political actors to count, exclude, and target people. What had been transformed into a label on paper later became a dangerous instrument in times of crisis. During the Genocide against the Tutsi in 1994, identity cards were regularly checked at roadblocks and used to identify victims. This shows the long historical consequences of colonial “ethnicism” practices.



Fig.5.4: An identity card specifying the ethnic origin. Source: https://cateacherscollaborative.org/wp-content/uploads/Lesson-3B_-Ethnic-Identity-Cards_Twige-Project.pdf

5.2.5 Consequences of “ethnic” practices in Rwanda

“Ethnic” colonial practices produced long-lasting consequences. They spread stereotypes that presented difference as natural inequality. They made some communities feel privileged and others excluded. They linked ethnicity to administration, education, and political representation. They also weakened trust among Rwandans by encouraging people to interpret social and political problems through “ethnic” categories rather than through common citizenship.

These practices also contributed to later violence such as 1959 crisis. As “ethnic” labels became more rigid, political entrepreneurs could mobilize support more easily by claiming to defend one group against another. Exclusion from schools, public office, and social opportunity fed resentment.

In the longer term, these processes contributed to cycles of discrimination, persecution, forced exile, and eventually the 1994 genocide against the Tutsi. Studying these

consequences helps students to understand why colonial “ethnic” division must be rejected and why unity requires both historical truth and responsible civic action.

Note that the history of social relations between Rwandans cannot be oversimplified to a Hutu-Tutsi-Twa divide. Such divisions, if they ever existed, could not have led to the establishment of a united national community. Indeed, there also existed many factors of commonality, such as language, religious practices, common habitat, clan network, wars against neighboring kingdoms, and a feeling of patriotism.

Application activity 5.2



Instructions:

1. Prepare key speaking points for a community meeting on unity.
2. Use the lesson to explain causes, consequences, and the need to reject stereotypes.
3. Present your ideas in clear, well-developed sentences and include one civic lesson for today.

Case study: Youth Voices for Unity

A group of students has been invited to speak at a community meeting on the theme of unity. They decide to explain how colonial administration, mission schools, and “ethnic” identity cards contributed to divisionism in Rwanda.

They also want to show that learning this history should not divide people again, but should instead help them to reject stereotypes and defend equal citizenship.

Questions:

1. How would you explain, step by step, the role of colonial power and Catholic clergy in promoting ethnicity in Rwanda?
2. Which short-term and long-term consequences would you present to the community, and why?
3. What message should students give so that studying this history helps to strengthen unity rather than revive division?

5.3. The Trusteeship (1946–1962) and “ethnic” awakening

Learning activity 5.3



Instructions:

Read the situation carefully.

Before reading the section, identify the signs of political reform and the signs of growing tension.

Predict why a period meant to prepare Rwanda for self-government might still produce conflict.

Share your ideas and questions with the class.

Scenario:

Rwanda is told that it is being prepared for self-government. New councils are introduced and people begin to speak more openly about reform. At the same time, different groups start publishing rival political ideas, old grievances become sharper, alliances change, and violence begins to appear. Students are asked to think about why a process that promises independence can also produce fear, competition, and division.

Questions:

1. Which details in the scenario suggest hope for political change?
2. Which details suggest that the same process could lead to tension or conflict?
3. Why might reforms create competition if some groups feel excluded or mistrusted?

Rwanda was placed under United Nations Trusteeship on 13 December 1946. In principle, the Trusteeship system was meant to prepare the population for self-government and independence. In practice, however, reform was slow, uneven, and deeply shaped by the colonial structures already in place. The years between 1946 and 1962 moved rapidly from debate about reform to violence, exile, and the end of the monarchy.

5.3.1 Challenges on the eve of decolonisation

The 1952 decree introduced consultative councils at sub-chieftaincy, chieftaincy, territorial, and national levels. Although these institutions opened some political space, they remained dominated by the Tutsi elite favored by the colonial system. The 1956 amendments, including broader suffrage at sub-chieftaincy level, did not substantially change the situation at higher levels. Many Hutu elites felt excluded, while some Tutsi elites were also frustrated by the slow pace of decolonisation.

At the same time, the United Nations criticized Belgium for the slow political evolution of the territory. Belgian officials still hoped for a long timetable before independence, influenced by ideas such as the Van Bilsen plan for gradual decolonization. Yet events inside Rwanda moved faster than colonial planners expected.

5.3.2 Protests by the Rwandan elite

Like educated elites elsewhere in Africa, Rwandan elites increasingly challenged colonial rule in the 1950s. Some were close to missions or administration; others were more nationalist in outlook. In February 1957, members of the Higher National Council published the *Mise au Point*.

This document asked for stronger education, more power for the king and the Higher National Council, real social and economic development, and an end to racial discrimination between whites and blacks. Its tone was moderate, but it clearly pointed toward autonomy and later independence.

The Belgian administration did not respond officially to the *Mise au Point*. Instead, the public debate was transformed by the publication of the *Bahutu Manifesto* in March 1957. This document highlighted genuine grievances related to exclusion from power, education, and opportunity, but it framed these problems mainly as the oppression of Hutu by Tutsi. In doing so, it pushed political discussion away from a broader anti-colonial critique and toward an “ethnic” interpretation of Rwanda’s crisis.

5.3.3 Reactions to “ethnic” politics

The ethnic turn was not accepted by all actors. In 1956 and 1958, discussions in the Higher National Council rejected attempts to make politics revolve around rigid Hutu, Tutsi, and Twa representation. Some members argued that Rwanda was one community, that all Banyarwanda should work for common progress, and that merit rather than “ethnic” group should guide appointments.

However, the debate did not disappear. Petitioners raised concerns about representation, access to education, administrative abuse, and social inequality. These were real issues. The problem was that the Trusteeship power failed to lead them toward a common political solution. Instead, as the debate hardened, colonial and mission actors increasingly looked for alliances that would best protect their own interests.

5.3.4 Shift in Belgian alliance and support for Hutu emancipation

By late 1958, the Belgian authorities changed course. Harroy publicly recognized inequality between Tutsi officeholders and the largely poor Hutu masses, while also presenting the problem mainly as one internal to Rwandan society.

In reality, Belgium was abandoning its earlier reliance on the Tutsi aristocracy and moving toward support for Hutu emancipation. This strategy served Belgian interests because the new Hutu elite did not fundamentally attack colonial rule and could become a safer partner during decolonisation.

This shift was reinforced by important Catholic networks and the result was not the end of “ethnic” thinking but its political reversal. Colonial power, mission media, and new political actors increasingly framed the future of Rwanda through the language of “ethnic” rather than shared nationhood.

5.3.5 From the death of Rudahigwa to the 1959 violence

The death of King Mutara III Rudahigwa on 25 July 1959, under circumstances that remained controversial, created a political vacuum. Jean-Baptiste Ndahindurwa became Kigeli V, but trust between the court and the Trusteeship authorities was already collapsing.

Political parties soon multiplied: between September 1959 and May 1960 there were twenty parties, although only a few dominated the scene, especially UNAR, MDR-PARMEHUTU, APROSOMA, and RADER.

- **UNAR** (Union Nationale Rwandaise/ Rwandese National Union) presented itself as *nationalist and anti-colonial, demanding rapid independence and national unity*.

- **PARMEHUTU** (Parti du Mouvement pour l'Emancipation Hutu/ Movement-Party of the Hutu Emancipation). In the beginning, it seemed to advocate for constitutional monarchy. However, later on, it *advocated for a republican state*.
- **RADER** (Rassemblement Democratique Rwandais/ Rwandan Democratic Assembly) was a moderate political party and it *advocated for gradual political reforms rather than radical change*. This Party was quite close to the colonial administration and the Catholic Church.
- **APROSOMA** (Association pour la Promotion Sociale de la Masse/ Association for the Social Promotion of the Masse). It was active during the period of political transformation leading up to the 1959 crisis. The day-to-day activities of APROSOMA *were not far different from that of PARMEHUTU*

The violence of November 1959 unfolded in this tense climate. Party propaganda, rumors, local rivalries, and weak colonial response made the situation explosive. Belgian support for Hutu leaders was strengthened by the arrival of Colonel Guy Logiest, who backed the replacement of many Tutsi chiefs and deputy-chiefs with Hutu officials and took strong measures against UNAR. These changes helped PARMEHUTU expand and transformed the political balance of the country.



Fig. 5.5: Yuhi V Musinga with members of his family, c. 1910. The monarchy later came under sustained pressure from Belgian rule.



Fig. 5.6:Portrait of Gustav Adolf von Götzen, one of the early European visitors whose writings helped spread colonial interpretations of Rwanda

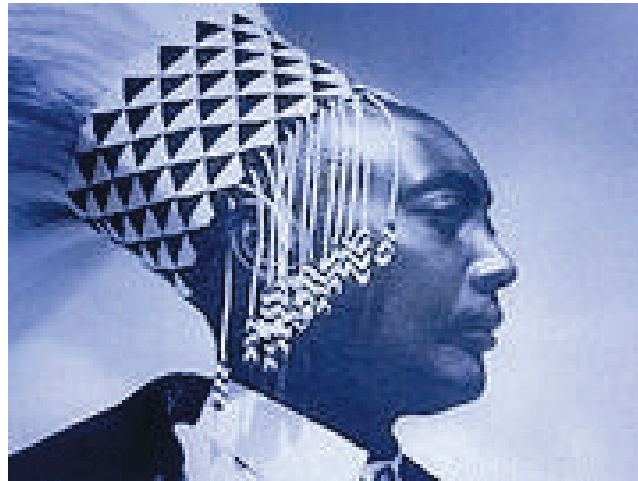


Fig. 5.7: Mutara III Rudahigwa. His death in July 1959 deepened the political crisis.



Fig. 5.8: John Hanning Speke. His writings influenced broader ethnic thinking about East Africa and the Great Lakes.

5.3.6 Immediate outcomes, 1959–1962

The dismissal of chiefs and deputy-chiefs after the November 1959 violence was a turning point. Colonial authority justified these changes as a response to the demands of the Hutu, but they were also a direct exercise of power that reshaped local leadership in favour of parties supported by Belgium.

Violence, arrests, exile, and destruction of property followed. Many Tutsi were killed other fled the country, and refugee communities began to form inside and outside Rwanda.

Between 1959 and 1962, therefore, “ethnic” awakening did not simply mean a new awareness of identity. It meant the politicization of identity through institutions, propaganda, reform, and violence. The result was the collapse of the old monarchy, the rise of the republican order, and the transmission of a deeply divided political culture into the post-colonial period.

Table 5.3 Timeline of key stages, 1946–1962

Year	Event	Historical significance
1946	Rwanda placed under UN Trusteeship	Self-rule became the official goal, but reform remained slow and controlled.
1952	Consultative councils introduced	Political space opened, but the system still favoured the Tutsi elite.
1956	Further electoral reform at lower level	Hutu representation improved slightly at sub-chieftaincy level, but not at higher levels.
1957	Mise au Point and Bahutu Manifesto	Competing visions emerged; politics took a strong “ethnic” turn.
1958	Belgian alliance begins to shift	Support for Hutu emancipation grew as Belgium sought a safer political partner.
25 July 1959	Death of Mutara III Rudahigwa	A major political crisis and violence against the Tutsi followed.
Late 1959	Multiparty politics and November violence	“Ethnicized” competition led to violence and killing the Tutsi, dismissals, exile, and institutional transformation.
1960–1962	Republican transition	The monarchy ended and the new state emerged in a climate marked by “ethnic” polarisation.

Application activity 5.3**Instructions:**

1. Prepare a short outline for a youth forum presentation.
2. Use the lesson to explain the major changes of the Trusteeship period, their causes and effects, and the lessons for today.
3. Present your ideas in clear sentences and propose practical actions that young people can take to protect unity.

Task context: Preparing a Youth Forum on Unity

A youth club in your district wants to organize a forum on how historical division was created in Rwanda and how today's young people can protect unity. You are asked to explain what happened during the Trusteeship period and to suggest useful civic lessons for the present.

Questions:

1. How would you explain the major political changes of the Trusteeship period (1946–1962) to forum participants?

2. Identify the main causes and effects of ethnic awakening during this period?
3. Explain civic lessons and practical actions should young people apply today to protect unity in Rwanda?

5.4 End of unit assessment

Summative assessment 5

Instructions:

- Use your knowledge and the scenario to answer in clear, well-structured sentences, showing understanding of colonial divisionism and giving relevant examples.
- Think critically by analyzing and evaluating, explaining causes, effects, and supporting your ideas with clear reasons.
- Apply your learning to real-life situations by proposing practical solutions and creating a meaningful product that promotes unity and responsible citizenship.

Scenario: Building a United Community

You are part of a youth committee in your community. The committee has been asked to prepare a presentation on how historical colonial policies contributed to division among Rwandans and how young people today can promote unity. Your group must prepare a well-structured response that explains the past and suggests practical solutions for the present and future.

A. Knowledge and understanding

1. Give two major European theories on Rwandan immigration and settlement.
2. Explain how linguistic and anthropological interpretations were used to support colonial ideas about "ethnicity" in Rwanda.
3. Identify three ways in which colonial power and the Catholic clergy promoted "ethnicity" in Rwandan society.
4. State two consequences of introducing "ethnicity" on official identity documents.

B. Skills

5. Analyse how indirect rule and administrative reform changed the balance of power in Rwanda during colonial rule.
6. Evaluate how colonial divisionism prepared the ground for later violence in Rwanda.

Section C: Attitudes and values

7. As a youth leader, propose practical strategies that can help overcome the effects of divisionism and promote unity in your community.

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UNIT 6

GENOCIDE IN COMPARISON: PATTERNS OF DESTRUCTION



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse similarities and differences between the 1994 Genocide perpetrated against the Tutsi and other cases of Genocide in the world with a commitment to **Never Again**.

Fig. 6.1: Illustration of genocides in comparison

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, learners should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

Describe different cases of genocide in the world.

1

Explain the similarities and the differences between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and the other genocides.

Skills

Analyse different cases of genocide in the world.

2

Identify the similarities and the differences between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and the other genocides.

Attitudes and Values

3

Judge different cases of genocide in the world.

Appreciate the similarities and the differences between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and the other genocides.

Introduction

This unit examines genocide through comparison. Instead of studying each case in isolation, it helps students look for recurring patterns such as discrimination, dehumanization, propaganda, organized violence, silence of bystanders, and the destruction of targeted groups.

The unit also shows that genocides do not happen in exactly the same way. Each case develops in a particular historical context, with its own leaders, methods, duration, and local or international response. Comparing cases, therefore helps students understand both common warning signs and specific differences.

Lastly, the unit looks at measures used to rebuild Rwandan society after the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. These measures include security, justice, unity and reconciliation, good governance, remembrance, and support for survivors. Studying reconstruction is important because preventing genocide is not only about stopping violence; it is also about rebuilding trust and protecting human dignity after violence.

Key words

- Genocide
- Discrimination
- Ideology
- Propaganda
- Prevention
- Justice
- Reconciliation
- Memory
- Accountability
- Human rights.

Introductory activity 6



Instructions:

1. Read the situation carefully and discuss the questions before the lesson begins.
2. Share your ideas in simple sentences and listen respectfully to others.

Situation:

In a certain community, people begin to separate themselves according to identity and background. Rumours spread on social media and in local meetings. Some leaders start blaming one group for poverty, insecurity, and unemployment. Shops begin refusing to serve some families, children repeat hateful words at school, and people become afraid of one another.

Questions:

1. Identify the signs that show that the situation is becoming dangerous?
2. Why can hateful words and false accusations lead to violence?
3. Explain what should responsible leaders and citizens do immediately?
4. Why is it useful to study past genocides when thinking about this situation?

6.1 Different genocides that occurred in the 20th Century

Learning activity 6.1



Instructions:

1. Read the short clues below before studying the lesson content.
2. Use your prior knowledge to answer the questions.
3. Keep your answers short and clear.

Starter prompt:

Case A: People are pushed off their land, chased into the desert, and many die in camps.

Case B: A government passes racist laws, isolates a group, and kills them in camps.

Case C: Hate propaganda, militias, and political extremists organize the killing of civilians inside one country.

Questions:

1. Explain how warning signs are common in the three cases?
2. What information would you want in order to compare these cases well?
3. Explain why is it useful for historians to study several genocides together?

The word 'genocide' was derived from two words. It originated from a Greek word 'genos' meaning origin or species, and a Latin verb 'caedere', meaning to kill. It was coined by Raphael Lemkin, a Polish-born American lawyer who taught law at the University of Yale in the 1940s. He used the term for the first time in his book, "Axis Rule in Europe", published in 1944. He used this term 'genocide' uniquely to make it different from other crimes of mass killings.

A universal definition of genocide is found in Article II of the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide. This was approved by the General Assembly of the United Nations in 1948. It defines genocide as any of the following acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part a national, ethnic or religious group. It includes killing members of the group; causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group; deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part; imposing measures intended to prevent births on the group; forcibly transferring children of the group to another group.

This definition reminds students that genocide is not an accident. It is a deliberate crime driven by destructive ideas and organized action.

6.1.1 Genocide against the Herero and Nama in Namibia

The Nama Herero Genocide was not recognised for unknown reasons by the United Nations Organisation. However, many authors and specialists in the study of genocides qualify it as a pure act of genocide committed against the Nama and the Herero by German colonialists.

When German colonial rule expanded into South-West Africa, settlers and colonial authorities wanted land, cattle, and political control. The Herero led by their leader Samuel Maharero resisted this occupation in 1904 and in response, the colonial army used extreme violence to crush them.

German forces under General Lothar von Trotha organised his ground army and they surrounded the living areas and the livestock pastures of the Herero. They attacked and killed them. They only left a small opening through which the Herero could escape to the Omaheke desert. Water sources were controlled or poisoned, and many people died from thirst, hunger, exhaustion, and direct killing. Later, many survivors were put into camps and subjected to forced labour where disease and torture caused further death. About 80% of the Herero and 50% of the Nama people were wiped out.

This case shows that genocide can grow out of colonial conquest. It also shows that a state can use displacement, starvation, and camp systems as tools of destruction.

6.1.2 The Holocaust



Fig. 6.2: Auschwitz II-Birkenau, one of the Nazi concentration and extermination camps. Source: Wikimedia Commons, 2026.

The Holocaust was a genocide that occurred in Germany and its occupied territories during the Second World War. It mainly targeted Jews, though other groups were also persecuted and killed (Polish, Ukrainians, Russians) by Adolf Hitler and his Nazi regime. It had roots in racist and antisemitic ideology.

Nazi ideology falsely presented Jews as a dangerous enemy. Step by step, the regime excluded them from public life through racist laws, especially the Nuremberg Laws of 1935. Jews were therefore collected from various parts of Germany occupied territories in 1939-1945, forced them into ghettos and deported by train into famous concentration camps where they were murdered in large numbers. Most of them, however, died along the way. Those who survived the journey were killed in gas chambers.

The Holocaust demonstrates how propaganda, law, bureaucracy, war, and modern technology can be combined in a systematic genocide.

6.1.3 The 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi in Rwanda



Fig. 6.3: Kwibuka flame used during the 32nd commemoration of the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. Source: MINUBUMWE, Kwibuka 32 guidelines, 2026.

The 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi the systematic extermination of innocent Tutsi civilians targeting to exterminate them all. It occurred over a period of 100 days started from 7th April to July 4th, 1994. It was the fastest and cruelest genocide ever recorded in the history of humanity.

The 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi was not a sudden event; it was a long-planned campaign of mass murder in Rwanda. It has roots in colonial Rwanda: When the Belgian colonisers arrived in 1916, they treated the Hutu and the Tutsi as separate groups. The colonial power further polarized the groups by classifying Rwandans into “ethnic” groups and making it obligatory for them to carry ethnic identity cards classifying people according to their “ethnicity”. This promoted “ethnic” division among Rwandans.

After independence, the newly established political regime (1st and 2nd Republics) actively engaged in anti-Tutsi propaganda. This was marked by the exclusion of the Tutsi from the political sphere and massive violations of Human Rights. Hundreds of thousands of Tutsi were sporadically killed during a series of massacres that were culminated eventually in the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. In this genocide, more than one million Tutsi were killed within one hundred days for the sole reason of being Tutsi and some politicians moderate Hutu who refused to support the ideas and actions of the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi.

Political leaders, soldiers, gendarmes, militias, and local officials mobilized for killings in Kigali and across the country. Roadblocks, lists of victims, hate media, and local administrative structures were used to identify and murder the targeted population.

The 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi was stopped when the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) defeated the genocidal forces on July 4, 1994.

This case shows how rapidly genocide can unfold when hatred, organisation, and impunity come together.

Note

Across these three cases, the targeted groups were first represented as a problem, a danger, or an obstacle. This dehumanization made violence easier to justify.

Comparative study does not erase the uniqueness of each genocide. Rather, it helps students to recognize both common mechanisms and particular historical contexts.

Table 6.1. Summary: selected genocides

Selected case	Period and place	Targeted group	Main features
Genocide against the Nama and Herero	1904–1908, in German South-West Africa (Today Namibia)	Herero and Nama peoples	Colonial conquest, land seizure, extermination order, forced flight into the desert, poisoned water points, and deadly camps.

The Holocaust	1939–1945, in Germany and its occupied territories of Europe during the Second World War	Jews	Nazi racist ideology, exclusion laws, ghettos, deportation, concentration and extermination camps, and mass murder.
The 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi	April–July 1994, in Rwanda	The Tutsi	Long preparation through divisionism and hate propaganda, organized mass killing, militias and state involvement, roadblocks, massacres, and destruction carried out within one hundred days.

Application activity 6.1



Instructions:

1. Choose any two genocides studied in this lesson.
2. Answer the questions, then prepare a short class presentation.

Task context:

Your group has been asked to prepare a simple classroom chart that explains two genocides to younger students. The chart must be accurate, clear, and focused on prevention.

Questions:

1. For each of the two genocides, identify the targeted group, one main cause, and one method used.
2. State two lessons that these cases teach about genocide prevention.
3. Write a short prevention message of not more than three sentences for your school community.

6.2 Similarities and differences between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and other genocides

Learning activity 6.2



Instructions:

1. Read the short comparison prompt.
2. Predict possible answers before reading the lesson.
3. Use simple examples to support your ideas.

Comparison prompt:

Imagine two genocides. In both cases, leaders spread propaganda and organize the killing of a targeted group. However, one happens under colonial occupation over several years, while the other happens very quickly inside one country among people who shared language and citizenship.

Questions:

1. Identify the similarities in these two genocides?
2. What might be different?
3. Why is it important to study both the similarities and the differences?

Comparing genocides helps students see patterns. It also prevents oversimplification. Some features appear in many genocides, while others are more specific to one case.

6.2.1. Similarities between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and other genocides

- Genocide is usually preceded by discrimination, segregation, hateful ideology, and propaganda.
- Intention of destroying or completely wiping out the targeted group based on ethnicity, race, region, religion, among others
- The target-group is presented as dangerous, inferior, or unwanted and singled out as "different" and "other"
- Planning and organisation are important; genocide is not a simple and ordinary conflict.
- Genocide involves governments or powerful authorities, state institutions, militias, or other organised actors, either actively organising the violence or allowing it to happen without intervention or putting in place all necessary measures to destroy the targeted group.
- Victims/innocent people are killed because of group identity rather than personal guilt.
- Cruel methods are prepared and used to torture the victims

- The negative and severe consequences are common including death, trauma, displacement, poverty, denial, and social destruction.
- Perpetrators often claim self-defense, revenge, or a need to restore order to rationalise the killing
- Perpetrators portray the victims as less than human (dehumanisation) often using propaganda, stereotypes, or conspiracy theories. This makes violence seem acceptable or even necessary. (e.g., Tutsi were called “cockroaches” in Rwanda, Jews were called “rats” in Nazi Germany).
- International actors and local institutions often fail to intervene early, allowing the situation to worsen.
- There are mechanisms of denying the genocide committed.

Table 6.2. Common patterns in genocides and distinctive features of the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi.

Aspect	Common pattern in genocides	Distinctive features of the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi
Preparation	Destructive ideas, propaganda, and organised planning often come before mass killing.	The genocide followed decades of divisionism and extremist mobilization by the government, militia training, and hate media.
Duration	Genocide may be carried out in a short or long period	More than one million Tutsi perished in only one hundred days
Targeting	Victims are attacked because they belong to a group, not because of individual actions.	The Tutsi were targeted as a group, while some moderate opponents were also killed for resisting the genocidal plan.
Role of authorities	Governments, armies, militias, or powerful institutions often enable or lead the violence.	State officials, security forces, militias, and local authorities helped to organise and spread the killings.
Methods	Mass murder may use shootings, camps, starvation, forced displacement, or other forms of violence.	Killings were carried out rapidly through roadblocks, house-to-house attacks, massacres, and other direct forms of violence. Extreme forms of violence were used such as burying victims alive, raping, torture, starving victims to death
Effects	Genocides leave death, trauma, displacement, poverty, and long-term social destruction.	Rwanda faced massive loss of life, orphanhood, widowing, trauma, destruction of trust, and the task of rebuilding national unity.

6.2.2 Differences between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and other genocides

- Targeted group differs: Genocides target people based on ethnicity, race, religion, nationality, or political identity. In the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, Tutsi were mainly targeted as an "ethnic" group while in the Holocaust, Jews were mainly targeted through racist and antisemitic ideology.
- Duration/speed: Genocides may occur over many years, while others happen very rapidly within a short period. The Holocaust took place over several years, especially between 1939 and 1945 during the Second World War while the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi occurred very rapidly, mainly within about one hundred days, more than one million Tutsi were killed from April to July 1994.
- Perpetrators: During 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, many people were involved, killing their fellow citizens, their relatives and their neighbors whom they shared citizenship and culture. The government agents, militias, church members and security organs were all actively involved in the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. In Holocaust, Jews were mainly killed by Nazis while Nama and Herero were killed by colonialists.
- Methods used: The methods of killing and persecution may differ, including mass shootings, starvation, forced labor, concentration camps, use machete attacks and other weapons. In the Holocaust, the Nazi regime used concentration camps, gas chambers, mass shootings, forced labor, starvation, and poisoning of water. In the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, many victims were killed directly in communities, homes, churches, and at roadblocks using machetes, guns, grenades, and other weapons. Cruel and extreme forms of violence were used e.g. torturing victims before killing them, throwing victims in septic tanks alive, burying them alive in common graves, gathering them in churches and other places and burning them alive using gasoline, raping women before killing them, crushing babies in mortars or smashing them against walls.
- Role of propaganda: The type and spread of hate propaganda may differ, such as through newspapers, radio, political speeches, or social media. In Holocaust, propaganda was mainly spread through newspapers, posters, films, radio broadcasts, school materials, and political speeches controlled by the Nazi regime under leaders like Adolf Hitler. These tools were used to dehumanize Jews and other targeted groups and to justify persecution over many years. During 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, propaganda was mainly spread through radio stations (such as national radio station and RTLM), newspapers (like Kangura), political speeches, and local meetings. Hate messages were broadcast quickly and widely, encouraging people to identify, hate, and kill Tutsi during a very short period.
- Intervention: The international community did not intervene to stop the genocide in Rwanda. The 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi was stopped by Rwandans themselves. It came to an end when the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) defeated the genocidal forces in July 1994. In the Holocaust, genocide was stopped through external military intervention when Allied forces defeated Nazi Germany and liberated camps in 1945.

- **Historical causes:** The roots of genocide may differ and they include colonialism, racism, political extremism, economic tensions, or long-standing discrimination. The causes of Holocaust are linked to long-standing antisemitism in Europe, economic crisis after World War I, and the rise of Nazi ideology under Adolf Hitler. The Nazi regime promoted racist ideas, blaming Jews and other groups for Germany's problems, which led to systematic persecution and eventually genocide. The causes of 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi are linked to colonial history of divide and rule policy that classified Rwandans into "ethnic" groups.
- **Geographic scope:** The Holocaust was spread across an entire continent (Europe), whereas the 1994 Genocide was concentrated within Rwanda's borders, making it one of the most intense and rapid genocides in history
- **Post-genocide recovery:** Countries respond differently after genocide through justice processes, reconciliation, memorialization, or reconstruction efforts. The Holocaust response was largely driven by international courts. The Nuremberg Trials prosecuted major Nazi leaders for war crimes and crimes against humanity. Rwanda combined international justice with community-based system. Rwanda focused on national unity, reconciliation, and rebuilding society. The justice process included the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda (ICTR) and local Gacaca courts.

Prevention insight

Recognising warning signs early matters. Hate speech, organized exclusion, weapons distribution, impunity, and repeated attacks on one group should never be ignored.

Comparative history is useful because it trains citizens to notice danger before violence becomes irreversible.

Application activity 6.1



Instructions:

1. Compare the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi with other genocides studied in this unit.
2. Present your answers clearly and briefly.

Task context:

Your class is preparing a school anti-discrimination week. You have been asked to explain how comparison can help students to move from memory to prevention.

Questions:

1. State three similarities between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and the other genocide you chose.
2. Identify three differences between the two cases.
3. Point out two practical lessons your school or community can apply to prevent hatred and violence.

6.3 Measures that have been taken to reconstruct the Rwandan society after the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi

Learning activity 6.3



Instructions:

1. Read the situation and discuss it before studying the lesson.
2. Think about both immediate needs and long-term rebuilding.
3. Give short and clear answers.

Situation:

A country has just come out of mass violence. Many people are dead, many others are displaced, institutions have collapsed, survivors need justice, and citizens fear one another. Leaders now ask: how can peace be rebuilt in a way that is fair, practical, and lasting?

Questions:

1. What problems would need urgent attention after such violence?
2. Identify measures that could help rebuild trust and stability?
3. Explain why should reconstruction include justice, unity, and economic recovery together?

After July 1994, Rwanda faced enormous challenges: insecurity, displaced populations, destroyed institutions, deep trauma, ruined property, and the need to rebuild trust after genocide. Reconstruction therefore required more than one measure. It involved security, justice, governance, remembrance, reconciliation, and socio-economic recovery.

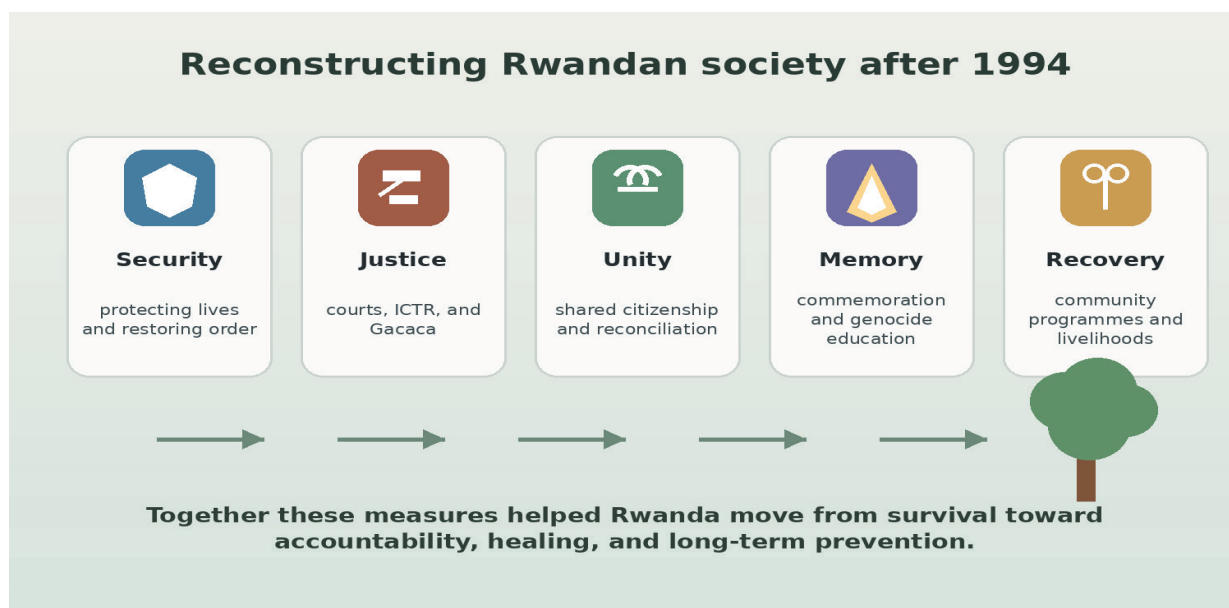


Fig. 6.4: Major post-1994 measures in Rwanda: security, justice, unity, memory, and community recovery.

Table 6.3. Major measures used to reconstruct Rwandan society after 1994.

Measure	What it involved	Contribution to reconstruction
Security and return of people	Restoring order, protecting citizens, and helping refugees and displaced people return.	Created safer conditions for survival, resettlement, and the restart of everyday life.
Justice and accountability	Use of national courts, the ICTR, and Gacaca to judge genocide crimes.	Helped to fight impunity, acknowledge crimes, and support accountability and reconciliation.
Unity and reconciliation	Policies and institutions that promoted shared citizenship, dialogue, and rejection of divisionism such as Itorero ry'igihugu, National Commission of Unity and Reconciliation (today under MINUBUMWE) were established. It abolished the use of identity cards that promoted "ethnicity" (Hutu, Tutsi and Twa) as Rwandan identities and promoted "Ndi Umunyarwanda" program.	Helped to rebuild trust and reduce the political use of "ethnic" labels.
Good governance and rights	Rebuilding state institutions, strengthening the constitution, human rights, and public accountability.	Made public institutions more stable and legitimate.
Community and economic recovery	Support from civil society, community programmes, and socio-economic initiatives such as Girinka, Ubudehe, Umuganda, and Kuremera.	Helped communities to recover, cooperate, and improve livelihoods.
Memory and prevention	Commemoration, memorial sites, genocide education, CNLG (National Commission for the Fight against Genocide) work (today under MINUBUMWE), and support for survivors.	Protected truth, honoured victims, educated the young, and strengthened prevention.

6.3.1 Justice, governance, and reconciliation

Rwanda used different justice mechanisms after the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. National courts and the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda (ICTR) prosecuted major crimes. Gacaca courts allowed many cases to be heard at community level and combined accountability with truth-telling and reconciliation.

The country also rebuilt institutions of governance. It strengthened state structures, reviewed the Constitution in 2003, promoted the rule of law, and established bodies such as the Office of the Ombudsman, the National Unity and Reconciliation Commission (today under MINUBUMWE), and the Human Rights Commission.

These measures were important because reconstruction after genocide requires more than punishment. It also requires public trust, fair institutions, and a shared civic future.

6.3.2 Social recovery, remembrance, and prevention

Reconstruction also took place in everyday life. Community-based programmes such as Umuganda, Ubudehe, Girinka, and Kuremera helped strengthen social support and practical cooperation. Civil society organizations and survivor-support initiatives also assisted communities.

Education was revised to address the history of genocide more responsibly and to fight genocide ideology. Memorialization became another important measure. Memorial sites, commemoration, and remembrance activities help preserve truth, honour victims, and teach younger generations the dangers of hatred and denial.

Laws on Genocide Ideology and related crimes are designed to prevent hate speech, protect unity, and ensure that genocide ideology cannot return. Abolition of the use of identity cards that promoted “ethnicity” (Hutu, Tutsi and Twa) as Rwandan identities and promotion of “Ndi Umunyarwanda” program.

The work of reconstruction continues over time. Building peace after genocide is not a single event; it is a long process of justice, remembrance, healing, responsible leadership, and active citizenship.

Application activity 6.1



Instructions:

1. Imagine that another country has come out of severe conflict.
2. Use Rwanda's experience to design a practical reconstruction plan.

Task context:

A youth forum asks your group to advise a country that is trying to rebuild after violent conflict. The country wants practical ideas that can help restore trust, justice, and development.

Questions:

1. Identify four measures from Rwanda's experience that you would recommend first.
2. Explain what problem each measure would help to solve.
3. State the results you would expect if the plan is followed seriously.

6.4 End of unit assessment

Summative assessment 6

Scenario:

You are a member of a school unity club. During a remembrance and peace week, your group is asked to explain what genocide is, compare the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi with other genocides, and propose practical actions that young people can take to prevent hatred and violence.

A: Knowledge and understanding

1. Define genocide.
2. Identify three genocides studied in this unit and identify the main targeted group in each case.
3. State three similarities between the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi and other genocides.
4. Mention four measures that helped reconstruct Rwandan society after 1994.

B: Skills

5. Compare the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi with either the Holocaust or the Herero and Nama genocide using causes, methods, and response.
6. Explain four warning signs that can show a community is moving toward genocidal violence.
7. Design a short prevention plan with five actions that a school or community can take.

C: Attitudes and values

8. Why should young people reject genocide ideology, discrimination, and hate speech?
9. State personal actions you can take to promote unity, memory, and responsible citizenship.

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